



Mounted Combat Guide for D&D 3.5e

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1. Introduction

What is Mounted Combat?

Mounted combat is a dynamic fighting style where you ride a creature (typically a horse) into battle. Your mount becomes an extension of your combat capabilities, providing mobility, tactical advantages, and devastating charge attacks.

Why Use Mounts?

Speed & Mobility

- Move faster than on foot (horses typically have 40-60 ft. speed)
- Cover ground quickly in outdoor encounters
- Chase down fleeing enemies or escape dangerous situations

Combat Advantages

- +1 AC bonus against opponents on foot
- Powerful mounted charges (double or triple damage with feats)
- Height advantage for better positioning
- Your mount can attack independently (if war-trained)

Tactical Flexibility

- Hit-and-run tactics with Ride-By Attack
- Mounted archery for mobile ranged combat

- Trample through enemy lines
- Control the battlefield with superior positioning

Overview of Benefits

- ✓ **Increased Movement:** Travel 2-3x faster than on foot
- ✓ **Charge Specialist:** Devastating lance charges with Spirited Charge feat
- ✓ **Defensive Bonus:** +1 AC vs. foot soldiers, +4 AC with Cover
- ✓ **Action Economy:** Your mount acts on your turn (controlled mounts)
- ✓ **Versatility:** Works for melee fighters, archers, and hybrid builds

2. Getting Started

How to Acquire a Mount

Purchase from Vendors

- Visit stables, ranchers, or animal merchants in towns
- Prices range from 30 gp (pony) to 400 gp (heavy warhorse)
- War-trained mounts cost 50-150 gp more than regular versions

Other Methods

- Paladin's special mount (class feature at 5th level)
- Druid's animal companion
- Purchased as starting equipment
- Captured/tamed in the wild (Handle Animal checks)

Mount Types Available

The game features **9 different mount types**:

Category	Mounts
Light Mounts	Pony, Light Horse, Light Warhorse
Medium Mounts	War Pony, Warpony (heavy)
Heavy Mounts	Heavy Horse, Heavy Warhorse
Exotic	Riding Dog, Dire Wolf*

*Some exotic mounts may require special training or class features

Choosing the Right Mount for Your Character

By Character Size

- **Small characters (Halflings, Gnomes):** Pony, War Pony, Riding Dog
- **Medium characters (Humans, Elves, Dwarves):** Any horse (Light, Heavy, Warhorse)
- **Size matters!** You must be at least one size smaller than your mount

By Combat Role

Melee Fighters (Paladins, Fighters, Knights)

- **Best Choice:** Heavy Warhorse

- **Why:** High HP, good AC, war-trained, powerful attacks
- **Speed:** 50 ft. (good balance)
- **Perfect for:** Lance charges, frontline combat

Mounted Archers (Rangers, Scouts)

- **Best Choice:** Light Horse or Light Warhorse
- **Why:** High speed (60 ft.), good maneuverability
- **Speed:** 60 ft. (excellent mobility)
- **Perfect for:** Hit-and-run tactics, kiting enemies

Versatile Combatants (Multi-class, Hybrid)

- **Best Choice:** Light Warhorse
- **Why:** Balance of speed (60 ft.) and combat ability
- **War-trained:** Can fight when controlled
- **Perfect for:** Flexible tactics, adapting to situations

Small Character Specialists

- **Best Choice:** War Pony
- **Why:** Proportional to rider size, war-trained
- **Speed:** 40 ft. (adequate)
- **Perfect for:** Halfling/Gnome fighters and paladins

Cost Considerations

Mount Type	Base Cost	War-Trained Cost	Total
Pony	30 gp	+50 gp	80 gp
Light Horse	75 gp	+75 gp	150 gp
Light Warhorse	N/A	150 gp	150 gp
Heavy Horse	200 gp	+150 gp	350 gp
Heavy Warhorse	N/A	400 gp	400 gp
Riding Dog	150 gp	N/A	150 gp

Additional Costs:

- **Saddle:** 10-30 gp (military saddle 20 gp recommended)
- **Tack & Harness:** 2 gp
- **Saddlebags:** 4 gp
- **Bit & Bridle:** 2 gp
- **Feed** (per day): 5 cp

 **Budget Tip:** A Light Warhorse (150 gp) offers the best value for most characters—war-trained and fast!

3. Basic Mounting & Dismounting

How to Mount (Step-by-Step)

Standard Mounting (Move Action)

1. **Position yourself** adjacent to your mount
2. **Select “Mount” action** from your action menu
3. **No check required** for standard mounting
4. **Cost:** 1 move action
5. **Result:** You are now mounted and occupy your mount’s space

Requirements:

- Mount must be at least one size larger than you
- Mount must be willing or trained
- You must have at least one hand free
- Mount cannot be prone

How to Dismount

Standard Dismounting (Move Action)

1. **Select “Dismount” action** from your action menu
2. **No check required** for standard dismounting
3. **Cost:** 1 move action
4. **Choose landing square** (any adjacent square to mount)
5. **Result:** You are now on foot

Landing:

- You can dismount to any square adjacent to your mount
- You land on your feet (no falling damage)
- You can move afterward if you have movement remaining

Fast Mounting/Dismounting (DC 20 Ride Check)

Fast Mount (Free Action)

- **Ride Check:** DC 20
- **Cost:** Free action (if successful)
- **Benefit:** Mount as part of your regular move
- **On Failure:** You fall prone next to the mount

Example:

Situation: Tordek the dwarf fighter needs to mount quickly to pursue fleeing orcs.

Action: Tordek attempts a fast mount (DC 20 Ride check)

- Ride bonus: +8 (5 ranks, +3 Dex)

- Roll: $14 + 8 = 22$  **Success!**

- Result: Tordek mounts as a free action and still has his full move and standard action

Fast Dismount (Free Action)

- **Ride Check:** DC 20
- **Cost:** Free action (if successful)
- **Benefit:** Dismount and continue moving
- **On Failure:** You fall prone in a random adjacent square

Example:

Situation: Lidda the halfling rogue needs to dismount and tumble past an enemy.

Action: Lidda attempts a fast dismount (DC 20 Ride check)

- Ride bonus: +10 (8 ranks, +2 Dex)

- Roll: 12 + 10 = 22  **Success!**

- Result: Lidda dismounts as a free action, then uses her move action to Tumble

Action Economy

Mounting Method	Action Type	Ride Check	Notes
Standard Mount	Move Action	None	Always succeeds
Fast Mount	Free Action	DC 20	Falls prone on failure
Standard Dismount	Move Action	None	Always succeeds
Fast Dismount	Free Action	DC 20	Falls prone on failure

Action Economy Example:

Standard Turn (on foot):

- Move action: Walk to horse
- Move action: Mount horse
- = No actions left **for** combat

Fast Mount Turn:

- Free action: Fast mount (DC 20 check)
- Move action: Ride toward enemy
- Standard action: Attack!

Common Mistakes

Trying to mount while in melee threat range without Mobility

- Mounting provokes attacks of opportunity
- Dismounting also provokes attacks of opportunity
- Solution: 5-foot step away first, or take the AoO

Forgetting you need a move action to mount

- Many new players think mounting is a free action by default
- You must succeed at DC 20 Ride check for free action mounting
- Budget your actions accordingly

Mounting a creature your size

- You must be at least one size smaller than your mount
- Medium characters can't ride Medium mounts
- Small characters can't ride Small mounts

Attempting to fast mount without Ride skill

- DC 20 is challenging for untrained characters
- Untrained Ride check = 1d20 + Dex modifier
- Invest at least 3-5 ranks in Ride for consistency

✗ Forgetting your mount's position after dismounting

- Your mount doesn't disappear—it stays on the battlefield
- Position matters for tactical control
- Remember to command your mount on subsequent turns

⚠ **Important:** Mounting and dismounting both provoke attacks of opportunity from threatening enemies!

4. The Ride Skill

Importance of Ride Skill

The **Ride skill** (PHB p.80) is absolutely essential for mounted combat. Without it, you'll struggle with basic tasks and won't be able to perform advanced maneuvers. Every mounted combatant should invest heavily in this skill.

Key Benefits:

- Control your mount in combat situations
- Perform advanced maneuvers (charges, leaps, cover)
- Stay in the saddle when attacked
- Fast mount/dismount for tactical flexibility
- Reduce ranged attack penalties (with Mounted Archery feat)

Recommended Investment:

- **Minimum:** 5 ranks (for consistency with DC 5-10 tasks)
- **Competent:** 8-10 ranks (for DC 15 tasks with good reliability)
- **Master:** 15+ ranks (for DC 20 tasks and extreme situations)

All Ride Skill DCs with Examples

DC 5: Basic Control Tasks

Guide with Knees

- **Task:** Control mount with your knees while using both hands for other purposes
- **Use:** Wielding two-handed weapons, using a bow, casting spells with somatic components
- **Check:** Made each round you need both hands free
- **Failure:** Mount not controlled, or you must use one hand to guide

Example:

Fighter wielding greatsword on horseback

- Round 1: Makes DC 5 Ride check to guide with knees → Success → Attacks with greatsword (two hands)
- Round 2: Fails DC 5 check → Must choose: use one hand for reins (1d10 one-handed) or lose control

Stay in Saddle (Reroll)

- **Task:** React instinctively to avoid falling when mount acts unexpectedly
- **Use:** Automatic check when mount rears, jumps, or makes sudden movements
- **Check:** Made reactively when triggered
- **Failure:** Fall from mount (see Soft Fall below)

Example:

Wizard's horse startled by fireball

- Horse rears unexpectedly
- Wizard makes DC 5 Ride check
- Roll: $3 + 2 \text{ (Dex)} = 5$  **Success!**
- Stays in saddle, can act normally

DC 10: Combat Readiness**Fight with Warhorse**

- **Task:** Control a war-trained mount in combat
- **Use:** Directing your mount to attack independently
- **Check:** Made each round you want mount to attack
- **Failure:** Mount doesn't attack (becomes uncontrolled that round)

Example:**Paladin on heavy warhorse charging orcs**

- Paladin attacks orc with lance
- Wants warhorse to bite and hoof the same orc
- Makes DC 10 Ride check → Success → Warhorse gets full attack
- Total: Lance attack + Bite + 2 hoof attacks!

Cover (Reaction)

- **Task:** Drop down and hang alongside mount for cover
- **Use:** Reaction to incoming attacks, especially ranged
- **Check:** Made as immediate action when attacked
- **Benefit:** +4 cover bonus to AC
- **Limitation:** Can't attack while using cover

Example:**Ranger notices enemy archers taking aim**

- Enemy archer attacks: $1d20+8$ vs AC 16
- Ranger uses Cover as immediate action (DC 10 Ride check)
- Roll: $12 + 6 = 18$  **Success!**
- AC increases to 20 ($16 + 4$ cover)
- Arrow misses!

DC 15: Advanced Maneuvers**Soft Fall**

- **Task:** Take no damage when falling from mount
- **Use:** Automatic when knocked off or mount killed
- **Check:** Made when falling/thrown from mount
- **Success:** Land on feet, no damage
- **Failure:** Fall prone, take falling damage if applicable

Example:

Fighter knocked off horse by giant's club

- Giant hits fighter: "You're knocked off your mount!"
- Fighter makes DC 15 Ride check
- Roll: $13 + 5 = 18$  **Success!**
- Fighter lands gracefully on feet, ready to fight

Leap

- **Task:** Cause mount to jump obstacles
- **Use:** Clearing barriers, chasms, or difficult terrain
- **Check:** Made when attempting jump
- **Success:** Mount jumps obstacle (if physically possible)
- **Failure:** Mount refuses or stops short

Example:**Knight needs to jump over fallen log during chase**

- Log is 4 feet high, horse can physically clear it
- Makes DC 15 Ride check
- Roll: $9 + 7 = 16$  **Success!**
- Horse leaps log, chase continues!

Spur Mount

- **Task:** Encourage mount to move faster temporarily
- **Use:** When you need extra speed for one round
- **Benefit:** +10 feet to mount's speed for 1 round
- **Cost:** 1 point of damage to mount
- **Limitation:** Can't spur exhausted mount

Example:**Paladin charging toward endangered ally**

- Heavy warhorse normal speed: 50 ft.
- Uses Spur Mount (DC 15 Ride check)
- Roll: $11 + 8 = 19$  **Success!**
- Speed increases to 60 ft. for this round
- Mount takes 1 damage
- Reaches ally in time to intercept attacker!

DC 20: Expert Control**Control Mount in Battle**

- **Task:** Control a mount not trained for combat (non-warhorse)
- **Use:** Using regular horses/ponies in combat situations
- **Check:** Made each round to maintain control
- **Failure:** Mount panics and flees or refuses commands

Example:

Ranger on regular light horse engaged in melee

- Light horse not war-trained (panics near combat)
- Each round: DC 20 Ride check to maintain control
- Round 1: Roll $15 + 10 = 25$ ✓ Horse controlled
- Round 2: Roll $8 + 10 = 18$ ✗ Horse panics and flees!

⚠ **This is why war-trained mounts are essential for combat!**

Fast Mount/Dismount

- **Task:** Mount or dismount as a free action
- **Use:** Tactical situations requiring swift mounting/dismounting
- **Check:** Made when attempting fast mount/dismount
- **Success:** Mount/dismount as free action
- **Failure:** Fall prone adjacent to mount

Example:**Rogue needs to mount mid-combat**

- Standard mount = move action (no attack this turn)
 - Fast mount = free action (can still attack)
 - Makes DC 20 Ride check
 - Roll: $16 + 9 = 25$ ✓ **Success!**
 - Mounts as free action
 - Still has move and standard action available!
-

Ride Skill DC Summary Table

DC	Task	Use Case	Success/Failure
5	Guide with knees	Two-handed weapons, bows	Success: Both hands free / Fail: Must use one hand
5	Stay in saddle	Mount rears/jumps suddenly	Success: Stay mounted / Fail: Fall off
10	Fight with warhorse	Direct mount to attack	Success: Mount attacks / Fail: Mount doesn't attack
10	Cover	+4 AC vs attacks	Success: +4 AC / Fail: No bonus, can't attack
15	Soft fall	Knocked off mount	Success: No damage / Fail: Prone + damage
15	Leap	Jump obstacles	Success: Clear obstacle / Fail: Mount refuses
15	Spur mount	+10 ft. speed (1 dmg)	Success: +10 speed / Fail: No bonus, still 1 dmg
20	Control in battle	Non-war mount combat	Success: Controlled / Fail: Mount panics
20	Fast mount/dismount	Free action mount/dismount	Success: Free action / Fail: Fall prone

How to Improve Ride Skill

Skill Ranks

- **+1 per rank** (maximum ranks = character level + 3)
- **Class skill bonus:** +3 if Ride is a class skill and you have 1+ rank
- **Best classes:** Fighter, Paladin, Ranger (all class skills)

Ability Modifier

- Ride is **Dexterity-based**
- Each +1 Dex modifier = +1 to Ride checks
- Consider taking Dexterity 14+ for mounted characters

Gear & Equipment

- **Military Saddle:** +2 circumstance bonus to Ride checks to stay in saddle
- **Masterwork Saddle:** +4 circumstance bonus (if available)
- **Spurs:** Useful for Spur Mount attempts (not a bonus, just thematic)

Feats

- **Skill Focus (Ride):** +3 bonus to all Ride checks
- **Mounted Combat:** Doesn't improve checks, but negates hits on mount

Magic Items

- **Horseshoes of Speed:** Doesn't affect Ride checks, but improves mount speed
- **Saddle of Cavalry:** May provide bonuses (DM discretion)
- **Gloves of Dexterity:** Improve Dex modifier → improve Ride checks

Example Progression:

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Level 1 Fighter (Mounted Combatant Build)
- Base ranks: 4 ranks
- Dexterity: 14 (+2 modifier)
- Class skill bonus: +3
- Military saddle: +2 (for stay in saddle)
- Total: +9 to Ride (+11 for staying in saddle)

Level 5 Fighter (Specialized)
- Base ranks: 8 ranks
- Dexterity: 16 (+3 modifier, from level 4 ability increase)
- Class skill bonus: +3
- Military saddle: +2 (stay in saddle)
- Skill Focus (Ride): +3
- Total: +17 to Ride (+19 for staying in saddle)

```

Class Synergies

Paladin

- **Ride is class skill:** Natural synergy
- **Special Mount** (5th level): Bonus to Ride checks with special mount
- **Heavy armor:** No armor check penalty for riding with military saddle
- **Best for:** Mounted charge builds

Fighter

- **Ride is class skill:** Plenty of skill points for Ride
- **Bonus feats:** Can take all mounted combat feats quickly
- **Weapon specialization:** Maximizes lance damage
- **Best for:** Charge specialists, lance masters

Ranger

- **Ride is class skill:** Natural outdoorsman
- **Track:** Find enemies to chase down
- **Archery combat style:** Perfect for mounted archery
- **Best for:** Mounted archers, skirmishers

Druid

- **Ride is NOT class skill:** Challenging to invest

- **Animal companion:** Can be mount (if appropriate size)
- **Wild shape:** Can become mount yourself!
- **Best for:** Alternative mounted strategies

⚡ Monk

- **Ride is NOT class skill:** Very challenging
- **No armor:** Vulnerable while mounted
- **Unarmored speed:** Often faster on foot
- **Best for:** Generally avoid mounted combat

💡 **Tip:** If Ride isn't a class skill for your character, consider taking 1 level dip in Fighter, Paladin, or Ranger for class skill access and bonus feats!

5. Controlling Your Mount

Controlled vs Uncontrolled States

Controlled Mount

- You actively direct your mount's actions
- Mount acts on your initiative count
- You can command mount to move and attack (if war-trained)
- Requires successful Ride checks for certain actions
- **Default state** for skilled riders on war-trained mounts

Uncontrolled Mount

- Mount acts independently on its own initiative
- Mount makes its own decisions (usually self-preservation)
- You're just a passenger—mount moves where it wants
- Can only use move action to guide mount where you want to go
- **Default state** for untrained riders or panicked mounts

🔑 **Key Distinction:** Controlled = you command, Uncontrolled = mount decides

War-Trained vs Regular Mounts

War-Trained Mounts (Warhorses, War Ponies)

- **Cost:** 50-150 gp more than regular version
- **Combat Training:** Won't panic in battle
- **Can Attack:** Will fight enemies when controlled
- **Easier Control:** Only DC 10 Ride check to fight with warhorse
- **Examples:** Light Warhorse, Heavy Warhorse, War Pony

Regular Mounts (Horses, Ponies, Riding Dogs)

- **Cost:** Cheaper (30-200 gp)
- **No Combat Training:** Panic easily near violence
- **Won't Attack:** Flee or freeze when threatened
- **Hard to Control:** DC 20 Ride check each round in combat
- **Examples:** Light Horse, Heavy Horse, Pony

Comparison:

Scenario: Charging into melee combat

War-Trained Mount:

- DC 10 Ride check to control → Usually succeeds
- Mount attacks enemies with bite/hoooves
- Stays in combat reliably
- ✓ Recommended for combat

Regular Mount:

- DC 20 Ride check each round → Often fails
- Mount panics and flees when check fails
- No combat contribution
- ✗ Not suitable for combat

⚠ **Critical:** Always buy war-trained mounts for combat characters! The extra 75-150 gp is absolutely worth it.

What Your Mount Can Do When Controlled

Movement

- Move up to its speed on your turn
- You decide direction and destination
- Can charge (mount + rider both charge)
- Can withdraw, run, or hustle

Standard Actions (War-Trained Only)

- **Full Attack:** Bite and 2 hoof attacks (for horses)
- **Single Attack:** One natural weapon attack
- **Ready Action:** Hold action for specific trigger
- **Cannot:** Use items, cast spells, or perform complex tasks

Free Actions

- Can communicate distress (whinny, snort)
- Can fall prone voluntarily

Your Actions While Mounted

- You can attack independently
- You can cast spells (with DC 5 Ride check for somatic components)
- You can use items
- You can make Ride checks for special maneuvers

Example Turn (Controlled War-Trained Mount):

Paladin's Turn (Initiative 18):

1. Move: Mount moves 50 ft. toward enemy
2. Standard: Paladin attacks with longsword
3. Mount's Attack: DC 10 Ride check → Success → Mount makes bite and 2 hoof attacks!

Result: 4 total attacks (1 longsword, 1 bite, 2 hooves)

What Happens When You Lose Control

Immediate Effect

- Mount becomes uncontrolled for that round (or longer)
- Mount acts on its own initiative (roll separately)
- You lose ability to direct mount's actions

Mount Behavior (Uncontrolled)

Regular Mounts:

- **In Combat:** Flee from danger (usually away from enemies)
- **Direction:** Away from nearest threat
- **Speed:** Run action (4x speed) in panic
- **Attacks:** None (self-preservation only)

War-Trained Mounts:

- **In Combat:** May stand ground or defend self
- **Direction:** Stays near rider, but chooses own position
- **Speed:** Normal move or withdraw
- **Attacks:** May attack nearest threat if cornered

Regaining Control

- **Next Round:** Make appropriate Ride check again
- DC 10 for war-trained mounts
- DC 20 for regular mounts in combat
- **Success:** Regain control, mount acts on your initiative again
- **Failure:** Mount remains uncontrolled for another round

Example:

Fighter on regular light horse in melee combat

Round 1: Fighter makes DC 20 Ride check → Roll 12 + 6 = 18 ❌ **Fails!**

- Horse panics and flees 240 ft. (60 ft. speed x4 run)
- Fighter is carried away from combat

Round 2: Fighter makes DC 20 Ride check again → Roll 17 + 6 = 23 ✅ **Success!**

- Fighter regains control 240 ft. from battle
- Must spend several rounds riding back to fight

Mount Panic and Fleeing

Triggers for Panic (Regular Mounts Only)

Combat Situations:

- Entering melee range of enemy creatures
- Being damaged by any attack
- Loud noises (explosions, thunderclaps)
- Fire or extreme environmental effects
- Smelling blood or seeing death

Panic Effects:

- Mount becomes uncontrolled (if controlled)

- Mount flees away from threat source
- Mount uses run action (4x speed)
- You must make DC 5 Ride check to stay in saddle while fleeing
- Mount won't stop until it feels safe (200+ ft. usually)

Preventing Panic:

- **Use War-Trained Mounts:** Won't panic from combat
- **High Ride Skill:** DC 20 check each round prevents panic behavior
- **Calm Animals Spell:** Can calm panicked mount (Handle Animal check)
- **Distance:** Keep regular mounts far from frontline combat

War-Trained Mounts DON'T Panic:

- Specifically trained to ignore combat stress
- Will stay in melee without fleeing
- Won't spook from fire, noise, or blood
- Much more reliable for any combat situation

Example:

Wizard on regular pony vs bugbears

Setup: Wizard rides pony (not war-trained) into ambush

Bugbear attacks pony:

- Pony takes 7 damage
- Pony panics! (regular mount, took damage)
- Wizard makes DC 20 Ride check to control: Roll 5 + 2 = 7 ❌ **Fails!**

Result:

- Pony flees at 160 ft. (40 ft. x4 run)
- Wizard makes DC 5 Ride check to stay in saddle: Roll 11 + 2 = 13 ✅ **Success**
- Wizard stays mounted but is carried far from battle
- Wizard's turn wasted, party down one spellcaster

💡 **Lesson:** This is why war-trained mounts are ESSENTIAL for any combat scenario!

Control Summary Table

Mount Type	Combat Control DC	Attacks When Controlled	Panic Risk
War-Trained	DC 10	Yes (full attack)	None
Regular (in combat)	DC 20	No	Very High
Regular (out of combat)	DC 5	No	Low

Action Priority for Mounted Combat:

1. ✅ Buy war-trained mount

2. ☒ Invest in Ride skill (8+ ranks)
3. ☒ Make DC 10 check each round (easy with 8 ranks)
4. ☒ Enjoy reliable mounted combat!

6. Combat on Horseback

Initiative (You and Mount Act Together)

Unified Initiative

- When mounted (controlled), you and your mount share the same initiative count
- Roll initiative once, both act on that count
- Mount's actions are part of your turn
- This applies ONLY to controlled mounts

Turn Order:

Example Combat:

- Fighter (mounted, controlled): 18
- Orc Warrior: 15
- Wizard: 12
- Fighter's Horse: (acts on 18 with fighter)

Fighter's Turn (Initiative 18):

1. Mount moves 50 ft.
2. Fighter attacks with lance
3. Mount attacks with bite/hooves (if DC 10 Ride check succeeds)

Uncontrolled Mounts:

- Roll separate initiative for uncontrolled mounts
- Mount acts on its own count
- You act on your count (as a passenger)

Tactical Advantage:

- Higher initiative = mount moves before enemies
- You can position mount and attack in same turn
- Enables devastating alpha strikes

Attacking While Mounted

Melee Attacks

- You can make melee attacks normally while mounted
- Use any melee weapon (one-handed or two-handed)
- Reach weapons work normally
- You threaten all squares around your mount

Two-Handed Weapons:

- Require DC 5 Ride check each round (guide with knees)
- **Success:** Attack normally with both hands
- **Failure:** Must use one hand for reins (can't use two-handed weapon effectively)

Example:

Fighter with Greatsword on Heavy Warhorse

- Each round: DC 5 Ride check to guide with knees
- Roll: $7 + 5 = 12$  **Success**
- Fighter attacks with greatsword (2d6+9 damage)
- If failed: Must drop to one hand (1d10+6 damage) or stop attacking

Reach and Threatened Squares:

- You threaten squares based on your weapon's reach
- Your mount's space counts as your space
- Large mount = you control more battlefield area

Mount's Attacks:

- War-trained mounts can attack when controlled (DC 10 Ride check)
- Mounts get full attack routine: bite + 2 hooves (for horses)
- Your attack and mount's attacks are separate
- **Example:** Fighter attacks once with lance, horse attacks three times (bite + 2 hooves)

AC Bonuses (+1 vs Opponents on Foot)**Height Advantage:**

- +1 AC bonus against melee attacks from foot soldiers
- Applies to opponents smaller than your mount
- Represents elevated position and harder-to-reach angles
- **Stacks** with other AC bonuses

Example:**Paladin on Heavy Warhorse (AC 18 base)**

- vs. Orc on foot: AC 19 (18 + 1 height advantage)
- vs. Another mounted opponent: AC 18 (no bonus)
- vs. Large Giant: AC 18 (giant is taller, no bonus)

Cover Bonus:

- Additional +4 AC if you use Cover maneuver (DC 10 Ride check, immediate action)
- Can't attack while using Cover
- Great for avoiding ranged attacks

Combined Example:**Ranger on Light Warhorse**

- Base AC: 17 (armor + Dex)
- vs. Goblin archer (ground): 18 (17 + 1 height)
- Goblin shoots: Ranger uses Cover (DC 10 Ride check)
- Roll: $14 + 8 = 22$  **Success**
- AC becomes: 22 (17 + 1 height + 4 cover)
- Arrow misses!

Ranged Combat Penalties

Standard Ranged Attack Penalty:

- **-4 penalty** to ranged attack rolls while mounted and moving
- Applies to: bows, crossbows, thrown weapons, ranged spells with attack rolls
- Reason: Mount's movement makes aiming difficult
- **Does NOT apply** if mount doesn't move that round

Mounted Archery Feat:

- Reduces penalty from -4 to -2
- **Essential** for mounted archer builds
- Still -2 penalty, but much more manageable

Comparison:

Ranger on Moving Horse (no Mounted Archery):

- Base attack bonus: +6
- Dexterity bonus: +4
- Composite longbow: +1
- Mounted moving penalty: -4
- = Total: +7 to hit

Ranger on Moving Horse (with Mounted Archery):

- Base attack bonus: +6
- Dexterity bonus: +4
- Composite longbow: +1
- Mounted moving penalty: -2 (reduced!)
- = Total: +9 to hit

Standing Still:

- If your mount doesn't move that round, NO penalty
- You can ready action: "Hold until after mount moves, then shoot with no penalty"
- Tactical consideration: sacrifice mobility for accuracy

Example:

Mounted Archer vs. Orc (AC 15)

Option 1: Move and Shoot

- Horse moves 60 ft.
- Ranger shoots (+7 attack with -4 penalty)
- Roll: $10 + 7 = 17$ vs AC 15  **Hit!**
- Advantage: Maintains mobility

Option 2: Stand and Shoot

- Horse doesn't move
- Ranger shoots (+11 attack, no penalty)
- Roll: $7 + 11 = 18$ vs AC 15  **Hit!**
- Advantage: Better accuracy, but static position

Using Two Hands While Mounted (Guide with Knees DC 5)

When Required:

- **Two-handed melee weapons** (greatsword, greataxe, lance)

- **Bows** (longbow, shortbow)
- **Two-weapon fighting** (sword and dagger)
- **Spells with somatic components** (most spells)
- **Using items** (drinking potions, wielding shields and weapons)

How It Works:

- Make DC 5 Ride check each round you need both hands
- **Success:** Control mount with your knees/legs, hands free
- **Failure:** Must use one hand for reins (can't perform two-handed actions effectively)

Frequency:

- Must check EACH ROUND you're using both hands
- Even skilled riders can fail occasionally
- Invest in high Ride bonus for consistency

Examples:

Fighter with Greatsword:

Round 1: DC 5 Ride check → 12  Success → Attacks with greatsword (2d6+9)
Round 2: DC 5 Ride check → 3  Failure → Must use reins, greatsword ineffective
Round 3: DC 5 Ride check → 9  Success → Back to greatsword attacks

Wizard Casting Fireball:

- Fireball requires somatic components (both hands)
- Makes DC 5 Ride check → 15  Success
- Casts fireball normally while mounted
- If failed: Can't complete somatic components, spell fails

Archer Shooting Longbow:

- Every round shooting requires DC 5 Ride check
- Success: Draw and shoot normally
- Failure: Can't nock arrow effectively (no attack that round)

Consistency:

Ride Bonus +0: 75% success rate (need 5+ on d20)
 Ride Bonus +3: 90% success rate (need 2+ on d20)
 Ride Bonus +5: 95% success rate (automatic except natural 1)
 Ride Bonus +10: Effectively automatic (can't fail except on nat 1)

 **Tip:** A military saddle provides +2 bonus to "stay in saddle" checks but NOT to "guide with knees" checks. Invest in Ride skill!

Combat Round Example

Paladin (Level 5) on Heavy Warhorse vs. Orc Champion

Setup:

- Paladin: AC 19, +7 to hit, 1d8+4 longsword damage

- Heavy Warhorse: AC 14, +6 to hit, bite 1d4+4, hooves 1d6+2 each
- Paladin's Ride: +8
- Orc Champion: AC 15, +8 to hit, 1d12+6 greataxe damage

Initiative: Paladin 16, Orc 11

Round 1 - Paladin's Turn:

1. **Mount Movement:** Heavy Warhorse moves 50 ft. toward Orc
2. **Paladin Attack:** Attacks Orc with longsword
 - Roll: $15 + 7 = 22$ vs AC 15 **Hit!**
 - Damage: $1d8+4 = 7$ damage
3. **Mount Attack Attempt:** DC 10 Ride check to command warhorse
 - Roll: $12 + 8 = 20$ **Success!**
 - Warhorse attacks with bite and hooves:
 - Bite: Roll $14 + 6 = 20$ vs AC 15 **Hit!** → $1d4+4 = 6$ damage
 - Hoof 1: Roll $8 + 6 = 14$ vs AC 15 **Miss!**
 - Hoof 2: Roll $19 + 6 = 25$ vs AC 15 **Hit!** → $1d6+2 = 5$ damage
4. **Total Damage to Orc:** $7 + 6 + 5 = 18$ damage

Round 1 - Orc's Turn:

1. **Orc Action:** 5-foot step toward Paladin, attacks with greataxe
 - Roll: $12 + 8 = 20$ vs AC 19 (Paladin's AC) **Miss!**
 - Paladin's +1 AC bonus (height advantage) made the difference!

Round 2 - Paladin's Turn:

1. **Mount Movement:** Heavy Warhorse stays in position
2. **Paladin Full Attack:** Attacks Orc twice (BAB +5/+0)
 - Attack 1: Roll $18 + 7 = 25$ vs AC 15 **Hit!** → $1d8+4 = 8$ damage
 - Attack 2: Roll $7 + 2 = 9$ vs AC 15 **Miss!**
3. **Mount Attack:** DC 10 Ride check
 - Roll: $6 + 8 = 14$ **Success!**
 - Bite: Roll $11 + 6 = 17$ vs AC 15 **Hit!** → $1d4+4 = 5$ damage
 - Hoof 1: Roll $15 + 6 = 21$ vs AC 15 **Hit!** → $1d6+2 = 7$ damage
 - Hoof 2: Roll $4 + 6 = 10$ vs AC 15 **Miss!**
4. **Total Damage:** $8 + 5 + 7 = 20$ damage
5. **Orc Total Damage:** 38 damage → **Orc drops to 0 HP, combat ends!**

Analysis:

- Paladin dealt 45 total damage over 2 rounds (27 from mount, 18 from paladin)
- Mount contributed 60% of total damage output
- +1 AC bonus saved Paladin from taking 13 damage (orc's missed hit)
- Controlled mount = 4 extra attacks (bite + hooves each round)

This is the power of mounted combat!

7. Mounted Charges

How to Perform a Mounted Charge

Requirements:

1. **Line of sight** to target
2. **Straight or nearly straight path** (no sharp turns)
3. **Clear path** (no obstacles or allies blocking)
4. **Minimum 10 ft. movement** required
5. **Maximum movement** = double your mount's speed
6. **Target must be within charge range**

Steps:

1. **Declare charge action** (full-round action)
2. **Select target** within charge range
3. **Mount moves** up to double speed in straight line toward target
4. **Make single melee attack** with +2 bonus
5. **Suffer -2 AC penalty** until your next turn

Basic Charge Example:

Fighter on Heavy Warhorse (speed 50 ft.)

Situation: Orc is 80 ft. away, clear path

Action: Declare charge

- Mount moves 100 ft. (50 x2 double speed)
- Easily reaches orc at 80 ft.
- Fighter attacks with longsword: +9 to hit (+7 base +2 charge)
- Roll: $12 + 9 = 21$ vs AC 15  **Hit!**
- Damage: $1d8+4 = 9$ damage
- **Downside:** Fighter's AC drops to 17 (19 - 2) until next turn

Charge Bonuses (+2 Attack)

Standard Charge Bonuses:

- **+2 bonus** to melee attack roll
- **No** damage bonus (unless using lance or special feats)
- **-2 penalty** to AC until next turn
- **Single attack only** (no full attack)

When Worth It:

- Need extra accuracy against high AC target
- Opening move of combat (alpha strike)
- Setting up for special feat effects (Spirited Charge, Ride-By Attack)
- Closing distance quickly to reach enemy

When NOT Worth It:

- Target is close (you could full attack instead)
- You'll be surrounded by enemies (AC penalty dangerous)
- Terrain is difficult or blocked
- You'd miss out on better tactical positioning

Movement Requirements

Straight Line Rule:

- Must charge in straight line or nearly straight line
- **Allowed:** Minor deviations (5-10 degree angle changes)
- **Not Allowed:** Sharp turns, zigzagging, or circuitous routes

Terrain Considerations:

- **Clear terrain:** Can charge full double speed
- **Difficult terrain:** Can't charge through difficult terrain
- **Allies:** Can't charge through squares occupied by allies
- **Obstacles:** Walls, furniture, trees block charges

Distance:

- **Minimum:** Must move at least 10 ft.
- **Maximum:** Up to double mount's speed
- **Example:** Heavy Warhorse (50 ft. speed) can charge up to 100 ft.

Examples:

Valid Charge:

Start Position [Fighter on Horse] ... 60 ft. straight line ... [Orc]
 ✓ Clear **path**, straight line, **within** 100 ft. **range** → Charge succeeds

Invalid Charge:

[Fighter on Horse]
 |
 | 30 ft.
 |
 ----60 ft.---- [Orc]

✗ Requires 90-degree turn → Can't charge

Blocked Charge:

[Fighter on Horse] ... 20 ft. ... [Ally] ... 40 ft. ... [Orc]
 ✗ Ally blocks path → Can't charge through ally

Spirited Charge Damage (2x or 3x)

Spirited Charge Feat (PHB p.100)

- **Prerequisites:** Mounted Combat, Ride 1 rank, Ride-By Attack
- **Benefit:** Deal double damage on mounted charge
- **With Lance:** Deal triple damage on mounted charge

How It Works:

Standard Weapon Charge (Double Damage):

1. Make successful mounted charge
2. Roll damage normally
3. **Multiply total damage by 2**
4. Applies to ALL damage (weapon + Strength + magic + other bonuses)

Example:**Fighter charges with longsword**

- Base damage: 1d8+4 (Strength)
- Roll: 7 + 4 = 11 damage
- **Spirited Charge: 11 x 2 = 22 damage**

Lance Charge (Triple Damage):

1. Make successful mounted charge with lance
2. Roll damage normally
3. **Multiply total damage by 3**
4. Already accounts for lance's 2x charge damage, then Spirited Charge doubles that

Example:**Paladin charges with lance**

- Base damage: 1d8+4 (Strength)
- Roll: 6 + 4 = 10 damage
- **Spirited Charge with lance: 10 x 3 = 30 damage**
- **With Smite Evil (+5 levels): 10 + 5 = 15 → 15 x 3 = 45 damage**

Damage Comparison:

Attack Type	Base Damage	Charge Damage	Spirited Charge
Longsword (regular)	1d8+4	1d8+4	2×(1d8+4)
Lance (regular)	1d8+4	2×(1d8+4)	3×(1d8+4)
Lance + Smite Evil	1d8+4+5	2×(1d8+4+5)	3×(1d8+4+5)

Maximizing Spirited Charge Damage:

1. **Use a Lance:** Automatically gets triple damage
2. **Power Attack:** Add bonus damage before multiplying
3. **Smite Evil/Favored Enemy:** Add class bonuses
4. **Magic Weapons:** Enhancement bonuses multiply too
5. **Strength:** Higher Strength = more damage multiplied

Devastating Example:

Level 10 Paladin, Strength 18, +2 Lance, Smite Evil, Spirited Charge

- Base: 1d8 (lance)
- Strength: +6 (18 Str with two-hands = 1.5x Str bonus)
- Magic: +2 (enhancement)
- Smite Evil: +10 (level bonus)
- Power Attack: +5 (trading -5 attack for +5 damage)

Total before multiplier: $1d8+6+2+10+5 = 1d8+23$

- Roll: $8 + 23 = 31$ damage
- **Spirited Charge:** $31 \times 3 = 93$ damage!

With critical hit (x3 crit):

- $93 \times 3 = 279$ damage! (This can kill dragons!)

⚡ **This is why Spirited Charge is one of the most powerful feats in D&D 3.5e!**

Lance Combat

Lance Special Properties:

- **Reach Weapon:** 10 ft. reach (can attack enemies 10 ft. away)
- **Charge Damage:** Deals double damage on mounted charge (before Spirited Charge)
- **Two-Handed Damage:** Gets 1.5x Strength bonus when used two-handed on charge
- **One-Handed While Mounted:** Can wield in one hand while mounted (normally two-handed)
- **Can't Use Against Adjacent:** Can't attack enemies adjacent to you (reach weapon limitation)

Why Lances Are Perfect for Mounted Charges:

1. **Reach Advantage:** Attack from 10 ft. away, safer positioning
2. **Automatic Double Damage:** On every charge, even without Spirited Charge
3. **Triple Damage with Spirited Charge:** Most devastating weapon for charges
4. **One-Handed Capability:** Free hand for shield or other items while mounted

Lance Charge Damage Breakdown:

Without Spirited Charge:

- Base: $1d8+6$ (Strength 18, 1.5x bonus on charge)
- **Charge multiplier:** x2
- Total: $2 \times (1d8+6) = 2d8+12 =$ Average 21 damage

With Spirited Charge:

- Base: $1d8+6$
- **Charge multiplier:** x3
- Total: $3 \times (1d8+6) = 3d8+18 =$ Average 31.5 damage

Comparison to Other Weapons:

Weapon	Base Damage	Charge (no feat)	Charge (Spirited)
Lance	1d8+6	2d8+12 (21 avg)	3d8+18 (31.5 avg)
Longsword	1d8+4	1d8+4 (8.5 avg)	2d8+8 (17 avg)
Greatsword	2d6+6	2d6+6 (13 avg)	4d6+12 (26 avg)

Lance Tactical Considerations:

Advantages:

- ✓ Reach keeps you safer (attack from 10 ft.)
- ✓ Devastating charge damage
- ✓ Can be used one-handed while mounted
- ✓ +2 AC from shield in off-hand

Disadvantages:

- ✗ Can't attack adjacent enemies (need backup weapon)
- ✗ Only effective on charges (normal attacks less impressive)
- ✗ Requires mounted combat to shine
- ✗ Expensive (10 gp for regular lance)

Recommended Build:

Equipment Loadout:

- Primary: Lance (1d8, reach, 10 gp)
- Backup: Longsword (1d8, 15 gp) [**for** adjacent enemies]
- Shield: Heavy Steel Shield (+2 AC, 20 gp)
- Total: 45 gp

Combat Strategy:

- Round 1: Charge with lance (devastating damage)
- Round 2+: Switch to longsword **for** melee
- **If** enemy flees: Charge again with lance

Lance Charge Example:

Paladin on Heavy Warhorse, Lance, Spirited Charge

Round 1:

- Spots ogre 60 ft. away
- Charges with lance
- Attack: +9 to hit (+7 base +2 charge)
- Roll: $15 + 9 = 24$ vs AC 16  **Hit!**
- Damage: $1d8+6 = 11$
- **Spirited Charge:** $11 \times 3 = 33$ damage
- Ogre had 29 HP → **Instant kill!**

Round 2:

- Goblin adjacent to paladin
- Lance can't attack adjacent enemies
- Draws longsword as move action
- Attacks with longsword: $1d8+4 = 8$ damage
- Goblin takes 8 damage, still alive

Round 3:

- Another ogre 40 ft. away
- Sheathes longsword (move action)
- Can't charge (no full-round action left)

Round 4:

- Charges second ogre with lance
- Hit: $1d8+6 = 10 \rightarrow 10 \times 3 = 30$ damage
- Second ogre also dies!

 **Tip:** Always carry a backup melee weapon (longsword/mace) for enemies who get adjacent after your charge!

8. Mounted Combat Feats

Mounted Combat

Mounted Combat (PHB p.98)

- **Prerequisites:** Ride 1 rank
- **Benefit:** Once per round, you may attempt a Ride check (DC = attack roll) to negate a hit against your mount

How It Works:

1. Enemy attacks your mount and hits
2. **Immediate action:** Declare you're using Mounted Combat feat
3. Make Ride check, DC = enemy's attack roll result
4. **Success:** Hit negated, mount takes no damage
5. **Failure:** Hit connects, mount takes full damage
6. **Limitation:** Can only use once per round (one negated attack max)

When to Use:

- **Critical hits:** Negate devastating crits against mount
- **Heavy damage:** Large damage rolls that could kill mount

- **Limited HP:** Mount is already wounded
- **Boss attacks:** High-damage enemy attacks

When NOT to Use:

- **Minor damage:** 2-3 damage from weak enemies (save it for big hits)
- **Mount has high HP:** Can afford to take the hit
- **Multiple enemies:** Better to negate the bigger threat
- **Low Ride bonus:** DC too high to reasonably succeed

Example:

Paladin's Heavy Warhorse (25 HP remaining) vs. Giant

Giant attacks warhorse:

- Attack roll: 23 vs AC 14  **Hit!**
- Damage roll: $2d8+10 = 18$ damage (would drop warhorse to 7 HP)

Paladin uses Mounted Combat:

- Ride check DC = 23 (giant's attack roll)
- Paladin's Ride: +12
- Roll: $15 + 12 = 27$  **Success!**
- Hit negated, warhorse takes 0 damage
- Warhorse still at 25 HP

Later that round:

- Goblin attacks warhorse: Roll 15 vs AC 14  **Hit!** (4 damage)
- Paladin already used Mounted Combat this round
- Cannot negate second attack
- Warhorse takes 4 damage → 21 HP

Build Recommendations:

- **Essential for:** ALL mounted combat builds
- **Priority:** Take this feat FIRST (prerequisite for other mounted feats)
- **Synergy:** High Ride skill makes this feat more effective
- **Investment:** Every +5 to Ride = 25% better chance to negate attacks

Tactical Usage:

Scenario 1: Boss Fight

- Dragon attacks mount: $2d8+12 = 24$ damage (potentially deadly)
- Use Mounted Combat: DC 28 Ride check
- Success: Save mount from massive damage
- Worth it: Absolutely!

Scenario 2: Trash Mob

- Kobold attacks mount: $1d4+1 = 3$ damage
- Don't use Mounted Combat: Save it for bigger threats
- Mount can afford minor chip damage

Maximizing Effectiveness:

Ride Skill Priorities:

- Level 1-4: Invest heavily (max ranks)
- Level 5+: Keep maxed, consider Skill Focus (Ride)
- Level 10+: Ride bonus should be +15 or higher

With +15 Ride:

- DC 20: 75% success (need 5+)
- DC 25: 50% success (need 10+)
- DC 30: 25% success (need 15+)

 **Tip:** Announce “I have Mounted Combat” at start of each combat so DM remembers you can negate hits!

Ride-By Attack

Ride-By Attack (PHB p.99)

- **Prerequisites:** Mounted Combat, Ride 1 rank
- **Benefit:** When mounted and charging, you can move and attack, then continue moving afterward

How It Works:**Standard Charge (Without Feat):**

1. Charge enemy
2. Attack enemy
3. **Stop** adjacent to enemy
4. Stuck in melee range until next turn

Ride-By Attack Charge (With Feat):

1. Charge toward enemy
2. Attack enemy when you reach them
3. **Continue moving** after attack
4. End movement anywhere within charge range
5. Escape melee range, avoid retaliation

Tactical Advantages:

- **Hit-and-run:** Attack and escape before enemies can counter
- **Avoid AoOs:** Don't stay in melee range
- **Reposition:** End in better tactical position
- **Kiting:** Mobile skirmishing tactics
- **Safety:** Minimize damage taken

Example:

Fighter on Light Warhorse vs. Ogre

Without Ride-By Attack:

- Charges ogre 80 ft. away
- Attacks with lance: Hit for 18 damage
- **Stops** adjacent to ogre
- Ogre's turn: Full attack on fighter (2 greatclub attacks)

With Ride-By Attack:

- Charges ogre 80 ft. away
- Attacks with lance: Hit for 18 damage
- **Continues moving** another 20 ft. past ogre
- Now 20 ft. away from ogre
- Ogre's turn: Can only move toward fighter (no full attack)

Movement Breakdown:

Example Charge **with** Ride-**By** Attack:

- Mount **speed**: 60 ft.
- Charge **range**: 120 ft. (**double** speed)

Timeline:

Start [Fighter]60 ft.... [Ogre]60 ft.... **End**

 Initial  Attack point  Final **position**

Total movement: 120 ft.

Attack occurs: **At** 60 ft. mark

Continues: Additional 60 ft. **after** attack

Synergy with Other Feats:

Ride-By Attack + Spirited Charge:

- Charge enemy
- Deal 3× lance damage (devastating)
- Continue moving away
- Enemy can't retaliate
- **Perfect combo for “jousting” playstyle**

Ride-By Attack + Mounted Archery:

- Charge into range
- Attack with lance
- Continue moving
- Next round: Shoot with bow from safe distance
- **Versatile hit-and-run tactics**

Build Recommendations:

- **Essential for:** Mobile fighters, skirmishers, archers
- **Less Important for:** Heavy cavalry (paladins who want to stay in melee)
- **Required for:** Spirited Charge feat (prerequisite)
- **Playstyle:** Favors DEX-based or mobile builds

Advanced Tactics:**Scenario 1: Multiple Enemies**

Setup: 3 orcs in a line, 20 ft. apart

Action: Charge with Ride-By Attack

- Attack Orc 1 (lance: 22 damage)
- Continue moving
- Attack Orc 2? (Only get one attack on charge)
- End movement 30 ft. past last orc
- **Result:** Hit one, avoided melee with all three

Scenario 2: Ranged Harassment

Round 1: Charge archer, attack with lance (30 damage)

- Continue moving 40 ft. away

Round 2: Archer shoots, moves away

Round 3: Charge again with Ride-By Attack

- Attack archer again (28 damage, archer dies)
- Continue moving to safety

Result: Archer never got good attack opportunity

Scenario 3: Tank Avoidance

Setup: Enemy fighter (high AC, heavily armored)

Strategy:

- Charge past fighter using Ride-By Attack
- Attack, continue past him
- Reach vulnerable backline (wizard, cleric)
- Next round: Threaten casters, not wasting time on tank

Terrain Considerations:

- **Open terrain:** Best for Ride-By Attack (long straight lines)
- **Tight quarters:** Less effective (can't continue moving far)
- **Difficult terrain:** Can't charge through it
- **Obstacles:** May block continued movement

 **Tip:** Think of Ride-By Attack as “jousting”—hit hard and ride past, don't get stuck in slugfest!

Spirited Charge

Spirited Charge (PHB p.100)

- **Prerequisites:** Mounted Combat, Ride 1 rank, Ride-By Attack
- **Benefit:** Deal double damage on mounted charge (triple with lance)

Covered extensively in Section 7 “Spirited Charge Damage”**Quick Summary:**

- **Standard weapons:** 2× total damage on charge

- **Lance:** 3× total damage on charge
- **Stacks with:** Power Attack, Smite Evil, magic bonuses, ALL damage sources
- **Why it's amazing:** Multiplies EVERYTHING, not just weapon dice

See Section 7 for:

- Detailed damage calculations
- Examples with different weapons
- Optimization strategies
- Level-by-level build progression

Build Priority:

- **Level 1:** Mounted Combat (prerequisite)
- **Level 3:** Ride-By Attack (prerequisite)
- **Level 6:** Spirited Charge (devastating damage!)
- **Fighter bonus feats:** Can get all three by level 5!

⚡ **Spirited Charge is the #1 reason to play mounted combat builds!**

Trample

Trample (PHB p.101)

- **Prerequisites:** Mounted Combat, Ride 1 rank
- **Benefit:** Attempt to overrun opponents while mounted, and your mount may make one hoof attack against any target you knock down

How It Works:

Standard Overrun:

1. Declare overrun attempt as standard action
2. Target can choose to avoid (step aside) or resist
3. If target resists: Opposed Strength check
4. Winner pushes through, loser knocked prone or blocked

Trample (With Feat):

1. Declare overrun while mounted
2. Target **cannot** avoid (must resist)
3. Opposed Strength check: **Use mount's Strength**
4. Success: Target knocked prone, mount deals one hoof attack
5. Failure: Your movement stops

Why It's Good:

- Forces enemies prone (easier to hit, -4 AC penalty)
- Extra hoof attack (free damage)
- Uses mount's Strength (usually higher than yours)
- **Can trample multiple enemies** in one charge if you succeed

Example:

Paladin on Heavy Warhorse (Strength 18, +4) vs. Goblin (Strength 10, +0)

Trample Attempt:

- Paladin declares overrun with Trample
- Goblin must resist (can't avoid)
- Opposed Strength: Warhorse +4 vs Goblin +0
- Warhorse rolls: $12 + 4 = 16$
- Goblin rolls: $8 + 0 = 8$
- **Warhorse wins!**
- Goblin knocked prone (-4 AC, can't attack this turn)
- Warhorse makes hoof attack: $1d6+4 = 8$ damage
- Paladin continues moving

Multiple Tramples:

If you knock down first target, you can continue and attempt to trample another enemy in your path!

Example:

Fighter charging through 3 goblins in a line

Goblin 1:

- Trample: Warhorse Str 18 vs Goblin Str 10
- Success: Goblin 1 prone, hoof attack (7 damage)
- Continue moving

Goblin 2:

- Trample: Success again
- Goblin 2 prone, hoof attack (6 damage)
- Continue moving

Goblin 3:

- Trample: Failure (bad roll)
- Movement stops
- Can't reach objective

Result: 2 goblins prone and damaged, but couldn't break through completely

Tactical Considerations:

When to Use Trample:

- ✓ **Multiple weak enemies** in a line (easy Strength checks)
- ✓ **Need to break through** enemy formations
- ✓ **Enemies have low Strength** (goblins, kobolds, wizards)
- ✓ **Want to prone targets** for allies to attack with advantage

When NOT to Use:

- ✗ **Single tough enemy** (better to just attack normally)
- ✗ **High-Strength enemies** (barbarians, fighters, ogres)
- ✗ **Need to deal max damage** (regular lance charge better)
- ✗ **Tight quarters** (not enough room to maneuver)

Strength Check Odds:

Your Mount Str	Target Str	Approximate Success Rate
18	10	~70%
18	14	~55%
18	18	~50%
18	22	~30%

Build Recommendations:

- **Situational Feat:** Not essential for most builds
- **Good for:** Mounted characters who face lots of weak infantry
- **Skip if:** You want max single-target damage (Spirited Charge better)
- **Consider if:** Your campaign has lots of clustered enemies

Synergy:

Trample + Ride-By Attack:

- Charge through enemy line
- Trample multiple enemies
- Continue moving past them
- Enemies prone, you're safe from retaliation

Trample + Party Tactics:

- You trample enemies prone
- Allies get +4 bonus to hit prone enemies
- Prone enemies can't stand up without provoking AoO
- Team coordination for max efficiency

Example Combat:

Fighter on Heavy Warhorse vs. 4 Kobolds (Str 8)

Round 1: Charge with Trample

- Kobold 1: Str check (mount 18 vs kobold 8) → Success → Prone, 7 damage (hoof)
- Kobold 2: Str check → Success → Prone, 6 damage
- Kobold 3: Str check → Success → Prone, 8 damage
- Kobold 4: Str check → Failure → Movement stops

Result: 3 kobolds prone and wounded, 1 still standing but blocking

Allies' Turn: Attack prone kobolds with +4 bonus

- Cleric attacks prone Kobold 1: +4 bonus → Hit! → Kobold 1 dies
- Wizard casts ray on prone Kobold 2: +4 bonus → Hit! → Kobold 2 dies

Analysis: Trample set up easy kills for party

 **Tip:** Trample shines when you need crowd control and have allies who can capitalize on prone enemies!

Mounted Archery

Mounted Archery (PHB p.98)

- **Prerequisites:** Mounted Combat, Ride 1 rank
- **Benefit:** Ranged attack penalty while mounted is halved (from -4 to -2)

How It Works:

Without Mounted Archery:

- Ranged attacks while mounted and moving: **-4 penalty**
- Makes archery nearly unusable while mobile

With Mounted Archery:

- Ranged attacks while mounted and moving: **-2 penalty**
- Much more manageable, viable playstyle

Standing Still:

- If mount doesn't move: **No penalty** (with or without feat)
- But defeats purpose of mounted mobility

Penalty Comparison:

Situation	Without Feat	With Feat	Difference
Mount moves	-4	-2	+2 to hit
Mount stationary	+0	+0	No change

Example:

Ranger on Light Horse, Composite Longbow (+2 Str)

Without Mounted Archery:

- Base attack: +6
- Dexterity: +4
- Bow bonus: +2
- **Moving penalty:** -4
- **Total:** +8 to hit

With Mounted Archery:

- Base attack: +6
- Dexterity: +4
- Bow bonus: +2
- **Moving penalty:** -2
- **Total:** +10 to hit

Impact: +2 to hit = ~10% better chance to hit = ~15% more damage over time

Build Recommendations:

- **Essential for:** ALL mounted archer builds
- **Skip if:** You don't use ranged weapons while mounted
- **Priority:** Take early (level 1 or 3)
- **Synergy:** Rangers, Scouts, DEX-focused fighters

Mounted Archer Tactics:**Hit-and-Run Archery:****Round 1:**

- Move 60 ft. toward enemy
- Shoot with -2 penalty
- Stay mobile, hard to target

Round 2:

- Circle around (60 ft. movement)
- Shoot again with -2 penalty
- Maintain distance from melee enemies

Kiting Strategy:

- Enemy charges you
- You move 60 ft. away (Light Horse speed)
- Shoot enemy with -2 penalty
- Enemy can't reach you (only 30 ft. movement)
- Repeat until enemy is full of arrows

Versatile Combatant:

- **Turn 1:** Shoot from horseback (ranged)
- **Turn 2:** Charge with lance (melee)
- **Turn 3:** Ride-By Attack, then shoot (hybrid)
- **Turn 4:** Shoot while repositioning

Strength: Adapt to any situation

Optimal Equipment:**Mounted Archer Loadout:**

- Primary: Composite Longbow +2 Str (400 gp)
- Backup: Lance (10 gp) [**for** devastating charges]
- Armor: Studded Leather +1 (1,175 gp) [Dex-friendly]
- Mount: Light Horse (150 gp, 60 ft. speed)
- Special: Efficient Quiver (1,800 gp) [store bow and lance]

Total: ~3,535 gp

Feat Progression (Mounted Archer Build):

Level 1: Point Blank Shot (prerequisite **for** many archery feats)
 Fighter Bonus 1: Mounted Combat
 Level 3: Precise Shot (ignore cover penalties)
 Fighter Bonus 2: Mounted Archery
 Level 6: Ride-By Attack
 Fighter Bonus 4: Spirited Charge (devastating lance charges)
 Level 9: Manyshot or Rapid Shot (more arrows per turn)

Example Combat (Mounted Archer):

Level 5 Ranger on Light Horse vs. Orc Raiding Party (4 orcs)

Round 1:

- Initiative 18, acts first
- Move 60 ft. toward orcs (now 80 ft. away)
- Shoot Orc 1 with -2 penalty: +8 to hit
- Roll: $14 + 8 = 22$ vs AC 15  **Hit!** → $1d8+2 = 9$ damage
- Orc 1 wounded

Orcs' Turn:

- Move toward ranger (orcs have 30 ft. speed)
- Now 50 ft. away from ranger
- Can't reach, no attacks

Round 2:

- Move 60 ft. away from orcs (now 80 ft. away again)
- Shoot Orc 1 again: +8 to hit
- Roll: $11 + 8 = 19$  **Hit!** → $1d8+2 = 8$ damage
- Orc 1 dies (17 total damage)

Orcs' Turn:

- Move 30 ft. toward ranger (now 50 ft. away)
- Still can't reach ranger
- Frustrated orcs!

Round 3:

- Ranger repeats kiting strategy
- Shoots Orc 2: Hit for 10 damage
- Orc 2 badly wounded

Result: Ranger dominates with superior mobility, orcs can never close distance

Advanced Mounted Archery:

Parthian Shot (not a feat, tactical maneuver):

- Named after ancient Parthian horse archers
- Ride away from enemy while shooting backward
- Requires high Ride skill for stability
- Ultimate kiting technique

Focus Fire:

- Target one enemy at a time
- Use mobility to avoid retaliation
- Kill isolated targets before group reaches you
- Don't spread damage across multiple enemies

Positioning:

- Stay 60-80 ft. from melee enemies (sweet spot)
- Too close: Risk getting charged
- Too far: Range penalties, hard to land shots
- Use Light Horse's 60 ft. speed to maintain perfect distance

 **Tip:** Mounted Archery + Light Horse = You're almost impossible to catch! Use superior mobility to dominate battlefield!

9. Advanced Techniques

Guide with Knees for Two-Handed Weapons

Comprehensive coverage in Section 4 "Using Two Hands While Mounted"

Quick Reference:

- **DC:** 5 (easy for skilled riders)
- **Frequency:** Each round using two-handed weapon/bow
- **Success:** Full control with both hands free
- **Failure:** Must use one hand for reins (can't use two-handed weapon effectively)

Recommended Ride Bonus:

- Minimum +5 for reliable success (95% chance)
- Minimum +3 for decent success (90% chance)

Applies To:

- Two-handed melee weapons (greatsword, greataxe)
- Bows (longbow, shortbow)
- Two-weapon fighting
- Spells with somatic components

 **See Section 4 for detailed examples and strategies**

Soft Fall When Knocked Off

Detailed coverage in Section 4 "Ride Skill DC 15: Soft Fall"

Quick Reference:

- **DC:** 15
- **Trigger:** When falling or knocked off mount
- **Success:** Land on feet, take no damage
- **Failure:** Fall prone, take falling damage (if applicable)

When It Matters:

- Giant's attack knocks you off mount
- Mount killed/destroyed beneath you
- Failed fast mount/dismount attempt
- Mount bucks or rears unexpectedly
- Combat maneuvers (bull rush, trip) against you while mounted

Example:**Fighter knocked off horse by ogre's club**

- Ogre hits: "You're thrown from your mount!"
- Fighter makes DC 15 Ride check
- Roll: $13 + 7 = 20$  **Success!**
- Fighter lands gracefully on feet
- Can still take actions this turn
- **Failure:** Would fall prone, lose actions, vulnerable

Build Consideration:

- Invest in at least +10 Ride bonus for 75% success rate on DC 15
- Military saddle helps stay in saddle (+2), but doesn't help soft fall

 **See Section 4 for more examples**

Cover Bonus (AC +4)**Detailed coverage in Section 4 "Ride Skill DC 10: Cover"****Quick Reference:**

- **DC:** 10
- **Action:** Immediate action (reaction to being attacked)
- **Success:** +4 cover bonus to AC
- **Limitation:** Can't attack while using cover

How It Works:

1. Enemy declares attack against you
2. You use immediate action to declare Cover
3. Make DC 10 Ride check
4. Success: +4 AC applies to that attack
5. You hang alongside mount, using it for cover

Tactical Usage:**Best Against:**

-  Ranged attacks (arrows, spells)
-  High attack rolls (when normal AC isn't enough)
-  Critical hit confirmations (cover bonus may prevent crit)
-  When you don't need to attack that round

Don't Use Against:

-  Weak attacks you'd probably dodge anyway
-  When you need to make attacks of opportunity
-  Area effects (cover doesn't help vs. fireballs)

Example:

Ranger vs. Enemy Sniper

- Sniper attacks: +12 to hit vs Ranger's AC 16
- Roll: $18 + 12 = 30$ (definitely hits!)
- Ranger uses Cover: DC 10 Ride check
- Roll: $8 + 8 = 16$  **Success!**
- AC becomes 20 ($16 + 4$ cover)
- 30 vs AC 20 still hits, but...
- Damage reduced, crit less likely

Alternative: If sniper rolled $16 + 12 = 28$

- With cover: 28 vs AC 20 still hits
- Without cover: 28 vs AC 16 also hits
- Cover made no difference this time

Synergy with Height Advantage:

Base AC: 17
 + Height advantage: +1 (vs. enemies on foot)
 + Cover: +4 (immediate action)
 = Total AC: 22

This can turn near-certain hits into misses!

 See Section 4 for more detailed examples

Spur Mount for Extra Speed**Detailed coverage in Section 4 "Ride Skill DC 15: Spur Mount"****Quick Reference:**

- **DC:** 15
- **Benefit:** +10 feet to mount's speed for 1 round
- **Cost:** 1 point of damage to mount
- **Limitation:** Can't spur exhausted mount

When to Use:

-  Chasing fleeing enemy (need those extra 10 ft. to reach)
-  Escaping dangerous situation (every foot counts)
-  Reaching ally in need (get there one round earlier)
-  Positioning for critical charge (need perfect distance)

When NOT to Use:

-  Mount already wounded severely (1 HP matters)
-  Long journey ahead (mount needs to stay fresh)
-  You'd reach target without spurring (unnecessary damage)
-  Mount is exhausted (impossible to spur)

Example:

Paladin chasing fleeing goblin

- Goblin: 40 ft. away, running (120 ft. this turn)
- Heavy Warhorse: 50 ft. speed (100 ft. charge)
- **Problem:** Can't reach goblin (only 100 ft. vs 120 ft.)

Solution: Spur Mount

- DC 15 Ride check
- Roll: $11 + 9 = 20$  **Success!**
- Speed becomes 60 ft. (charge 120 ft.)
- Reaches goblin!
- Mount takes 1 damage (acceptable trade)

Result: Charges goblin, Spirited Charge lance attack, 33 damage, goblin dead

Damage Consideration:

Heavy Warhorse HP: 45 average
 Spur damage: 1 HP
 Percentage: 2.2% of total HP

Unless mount is already critically wounded, 1 HP is negligible cost **for** +10 ft. speed.

Strategic Situations:**Scenario 1: Every Foot Matters**

- Ally surrounded, 65 ft. away
- Mount speed: 50 ft. (can't reach)
- Spur mount: 60 ft. (can reach!)
- Result: Save ally's life for 1 HP

Scenario 2: Charge Optimization

- Enemy is 110 ft. away
- Mount charge range: 100 ft. (can't charge)
- Spur mount: 120 ft. charge range (can charge!)
- Result: Spirited Charge instead of normal attack

Scenario 3: Pursuit

- Enemy runs 80 ft. away
- Mount speed: 50 ft. (can't catch)
- Spur mount: 60 ft. (still can't catch, but closer)
- Next round: Will be in charge range
- Result: One round earlier engagement



See Section 4 for more examples

Protecting Your Mount with Mounted Combat Feat

Comprehensive coverage in Section 8 "Mounted Combat Feat"

Quick Reference:

- **Feat:** Mounted Combat (prerequisite: Ride 1 rank)
- **Benefit:** Once per round, negate one hit against mount
- **Mechanic:** Ride check (DC = enemy's attack roll)
- **Success:** Hit negated, mount takes 0 damage
- **Failure:** Hit connects normally

Priority System:**Attacks on Mount (Priority Order):**

1. Critical hits → Always try to negate
2. High damage rolls → Worth negating (10+ damage)
3. Killing blows → Definitely negate **if** possible
4. Regular hits → Let mount take damage **if** minor

Example:

- Goblin hits mount: 4 damage → Let it hit
- Ogre hits mount: 18 damage → Negate with Mounted Combat!

Example:**Level 5 Fighter on Heavy Warhorse (30 HP)****Round 1:**

- Orc attacks mount: Roll 16 vs AC 14, hit! (1d12+4 = 10 damage)
- Fighter: "Not worth negating" → Mount takes 10 damage (30 → 20 HP)

Round 2:

- Ogre attacks mount: Roll 22 vs AC 14, hit! (2d8+10 = 18 damage)
- Fighter uses Mounted Combat: DC 22 Ride check
- Fighter's Ride: +9
- Roll: 14 + 9 = 23  **Success!**
- Hit negated, mount still at 20 HP

Round 2 (continued):

- Orc attacks mount again: Roll 15 vs AC 14, hit! (8 damage)
- Fighter already used Mounted Combat this round
- Can't negate second hit
- Mount takes 8 damage (20 → 12 HP)

Analysis:

- Without Mounted Combat: Mount would be at 2 HP (critically wounded)
- With Mounted Combat: Mount at 12 HP (still functional)

Mount HP Management:**Healthy Mount (75%+ HP):**

- Let minor hits connect (save Mounted Combat for big threats)
- Focus on offense
- Don't worry too much about chip damage

Wounded Mount (25-75% HP):

- Start negating medium hits (8+ damage)

- Be more conservative
- Consider positioning to reduce incoming damage

Critical Mount (< 25% HP):

- Negate any hit you can successfully roll
- Consider dismounting and fighting on foot
- Use healing if available

When Your Mount Dies:

Immediate Effects:

1. You fall (make DC 15 Soft Fall check)
2. Success: Land on feet
3. Failure: Fall prone
4. Mount's body becomes difficult terrain
5. You're now on foot (reduced mobility)

Tactical Response:

If Mount **Dies**:

1. Soft Fall check (DC 15) → Try to land gracefully
2. Assess **situation**:
 - Surrounded? → Fight defensively, try to escape
 - Winning? → Continue fighting on foot
 - Losing? → Withdraw, regroup
3. Consider backup mount (**if** you brought spare)
4. Adapt tactics to foot combat

Prevention:

- Take Mounted Combat feat (essential)
- Max out Ride skill (improves negation success rate)
- Position mount away from highest threats
- Use terrain for mount protection
- Have healing ready (potions, spells, wands)



See Section 8 "Mounted Combat" for full tactical analysis

10. Mount Types Reference

Complete Mount Comparison Table

Mount Type	Size	Speed	War-Trained	AC	HP	Best For	Cost
Pony	Medium	40 ft.	No	13	13	Small riders (non-combat)	30 gp
War Pony	Medium	40 ft.	Yes	13	13	Small fighters/paladins	100 gp
Light Horse	Large	60 ft.	No	13	19	Travel, scouts (non-combat)	75 gp
Light War-horse	Large	60 ft.	Yes	14	19	Mounted archers, mobile fighters	150 gp
Heavy Horse	Large	50 ft.	No	13	30	Heavy cargo, travel	200 gp
Heavy War-horse	Large	50 ft.	Yes	14	30	Heavy cavalry, paladins, charge builds	400 gp
Riding Dog	Medium	40 ft.	Yes	15	13	Small riders (alternative to pony)	150 gp

Detailed Mount Profiles

Pony

- Size: Medium | Speed: 40 ft. | War-Trained: No
- Cost: 30 gp
 - AC: 13 | HP: 13 (2d8+4)

- **Attacks:** Bite +0 (1d3), 2 hooves -5 (1d3)
- **Str:** 13 | **Dex:** 13 | **Con:** 14

Best For:

- Small characters (Halflings, Gnomes) who won't see combat
- Traveling, exploration, non-combat scenarios
- Budget-conscious characters
- Wizards, Bards, Rogues (support classes)

Pros:

- ✓ Cheapest mount option
- ✓ Appropriate size for Small riders
- ✓ Decent speed for travel

Cons:

- ✗ NOT war-trained (panics in combat)
- ✗ Low HP (dies easily)
- ✗ Weak attacks
- ✗ DC 20 Ride check to control in battle

Recommended Use: Non-combat situations only

War Pony

Size: Medium | **Speed:** 40 ft. | **War-Trained:** Yes

- **Cost:** 100 gp
- **AC:** 13 | **HP:** 13 (2d8+4)
- **Attacks:** Bite +2 (1d3), 2 hooves -3 (1d3)
- **Str:** 13 | **Dex:** 13 | **Con:** 14

Best For:

- **Small fighters** (Halfling/Gnome fighters, paladins)
- Combat-focused Small characters
- Charge builds for Small riders
- Any Small character who expects combat

Pros:

- ✓ War-trained (won't panic)
- ✓ DC 10 Ride check to control (easy)
- ✓ Can attack in combat
- ✓ Best combat mount for Small riders

Cons:

- ✗ Still low HP (fragile)
- ✗ Weak attacks
- ✗ Slower than horses (40 ft.)

Build Recommendation:

Halfling Paladin on War Pony:

- Level 1: Mounted Combat
- Level 3: Ride-By Attack
- Level 6: Spirited Charge
- Tactic: Lance charges (3× damage)
- Works despite slower speed

Light Horse

Size: Large | **Speed:** 60 ft. | **War-Trained:** No

- **Cost:** 75 gp
- **AC:** 13 | **HP:** 19 (3d8+6)
- **Attacks:** Bite +1 (1d4+1), 2 hooves -4 (1d4)
- **Str:** 14 | **Dex:** 13 | **Con:** 15

Best For:

- Long-distance travel
- Scouts and explorers
- Non-combat situations requiring speed
- Characters who can avoid combat

Pros:

- ✓ Very fast (60 ft. speed)
- ✓ Affordable (75 gp)
- ✓ Good HP for survival

Cons:

- ✗ NOT war-trained (terrible in combat)
- ✗ DC 20 to control in battle (very hard)
- ✗ Will panic and flee when attacked

Recommended Use:

- Travel mount for wizards, clerics, non-combat roles
- Scout mounts (stay away from battle)
- Backup mount (leave outside combat)

⚠ **Never bring Light Horse into combat!** Buy Light Warhorse instead.

Light Warhorse

Size: Large | **Speed:** 60 ft. | **War-Trained:** Yes

- **Cost:** 150 gp
- **AC:** 14 | **HP:** 19 (3d8+6)
- **Attacks:** Bite +4 (1d4+3), 2 hooves -1 (1d4+1)
- **Str:** 16 | **Dex:** 13 | **Con:** 15

Best For:

- **Mounted archers** (Rangers, Scouts)
- Mobile melee fighters

- Skirmishers and hit-and-run tactics
- Anyone who values speed + combat ability

Pros:

- ✓ **Fastest war-trained mount** (60 ft.)
- ✓ War-trained (reliable in combat)
- ✓ DC 10 Ride check (easy control)
- ✓ **Best value** (150 gp for speed + combat)
- ✓ Good for Ride-By Attack tactics

Cons:

- ✗ Lower HP than heavy warhorse (19 vs 30)
- ✗ Weaker attacks than heavy warhorse
- ✗ Less durable in prolonged fights

Build Recommendation:

Mounted Archer Ranger:

- Mount: Light Warhorse (speed!)
- Feats: Mounted Combat, Mounted Archery, Ride-By Attack
- Tactic:
 - Round 1: Move 60 ft., shoot (-2 penalty)
 - Round 2: Circle around 60 ft., shoot again
 - Round 3: Charge with lance **if** enemy closes
- Strength: Impossible to catch, devastating mobility

Skirmisher Fighter:

- Mount: Light Warhorse
- Feats: Mounted Combat, Ride-By Attack, Spirited Charge
- Tactic:
 - Charge with lance (3× damage)
 - Ride-By Attack (**continue** moving)
 - Never stop moving
- Strength: Hit-and-run specialist

💡 **Light Warhorse is the BEST VALUE mount for most characters!** 150 gp for speed AND combat ability.

Heavy Horse

Size: Large | **Speed:** 50 ft. | **War-Trained:** No

- **Cost:** 200 gp
- **AC:** 13 | **HP:** 30 (3d8+9)
- **Attacks:** Bite +4 (1d4+4), 2 hooves -1 (1d4+2)
- **Str:** 18 | **Dex:** 13 | **Con:** 17

Best For:

- Heavy cargo transport
- Long journeys requiring endurance
- Non-combat situations needing strong mount
- Pulling wagons, carriages

Pros:

- ✓ High HP (very durable)

- ✓ Strong (18 Strength)
- ✓ Good carrying capacity

Cons:

- ✗ NOT war-trained (terrible in combat)
- ✗ Expensive (200 gp) for non-combat mount
- ✗ Slower than light horse (50 ft. vs 60 ft.)

Recommended Use:

- Cargo hauling
- Pulling party's wagon
- Non-combat travel when you need durability

⚠ **For 200 gp more, buy Heavy Warhorse instead!** Combat capability is worth the investment.

Heavy Warhorse

Size: Large | **Speed:** 50 ft. | **War-Trained:** Yes

- **Cost:** 400 gp
- **AC:** 14 | **HP:** 30 (3d8+9)
- **Attacks:** Bite +6 (1d4+4), 2 hooves +1 (1d6+2)
- **Str:** 18 | **Dex:** 13 | **Con:** 17

Best For:

- **Heavy cavalry** (Fighters, Paladins)
- Frontline melee combat
- Lance charge specialists
- Characters who want maximum durability

Pros:

- ✓ **Highest HP** (30, very durable)
- ✓ **Strongest attacks** (Str 18)
- ✓ War-trained (reliable)
- ✓ Best for sustained melee combat
- ✓ **Perfect for charge builds**

Cons:

- ✗ Most expensive (400 gp)
- ✗ Slower than light warhorse (50 ft. vs 60 ft.)
- ✗ Overkill for some characters

Build Recommendation:

Paladin Charge Specialist:

- Mount: Heavy Warhorse
- Feats: Mounted Combat, Ride-By Attack, Spirited Charge
- Equipment: Lance, heavy armor, shield
- Tactic:
 - Round 1: Charge with lance
 - Damage: $3 \times (1d8+6) = \sim 42$ average damage
 - Mount HP: 30 (survives focus fire)
 - Durability: High AC + high HP = front-line dominance

Heavy Fighter:

- Mount: Heavy Warhorse
- Feats: Mounted Combat, Power Attack, Spirited Charge
- Equipment: Lance, full plate, tower shield
- Tactic:
 - Power Attack +5 (trade to-hit **for** damage)
 - Charge with lance + Power Attack
 - Damage: $3 \times (1d8+11) = \sim 55$ average!
 - Mount: Can take punishment, stays in fight

 **Heavy Warhorse is the KING of mounted combat!** Best for Paladins, Fighters, and anyone who wants to dominate melee.

Riding Dog

Size: Medium | **Speed:** 40 ft. | **War-Trained:** Yes (combat-trained)

- **Cost:** 150 gp
- **AC:** 15 | **HP:** 13 (2d8+4)
- **Attacks:** Bite +3 (1d6+3)
- **Str:** 15 | **Dex:** 15 | **Con:** 15

Best For:

- **Small character alternatives** (instead of pony)
- Halfling/Gnome rangers (thematic fit)
- Characters who want something unusual
- Indoor adventuring (dog fits better than horse)

Pros:

- ✓ War-trained (combat-ready)
- ✓ **Highest AC** among small mounts (15)
- ✓ Better in buildings/dungeons than horses
- ✓ Thematic for rangers, druids

Cons:

- ✗ Low HP (13, fragile)
- ✗ Only one attack (bite, no hooves)
- ✗ Same cost as Light Warhorse but weaker
- ✗ Slower than horses

Build Recommendation:

Halfling Ranger:

- Mount: Riding Dog (thematic!)
- Animal companion: Can use Handle Animal to improve dog
- Feats: Mounted Combat, Mounted Archery
- Tactic: Mobile archery on dog, fits in dungeons

Gnome Bard:

- Mount: Riding Dog (fits character concept)
- Use: Support role, stay away from melee
- Advantage: Can navigate indoors, horse can't

Special Notes:

- **Better indoors:** Horses struggle in dungeons, dogs fit better
- **Alternative to ponies:** Same Medium size, but combat-trained
- **Thematic choice:** Rangers and druids may prefer dogs
- **Less common:** Most players choose horses, dog is unique



Riding Dog is a niche choice, but excellent for Small characters who want something different!

Mount Selection Guide

By Character Size:**Small Characters (Halflings, Gnomes):**

- **Combat:** War Pony (best option) or Riding Dog (alternative)
- **Non-combat:** Pony (budget) or War Pony (versatile)

Medium+ Characters (Humans, Elves, Dwarves):

- **Heavy Melee:** Heavy Warhorse (frontline fighter)
- **Mobile Melee:** Light Warhorse (skirmisher, charge build)
- **Mounted Archer:** Light Warhorse (speed is key)
- **Non-combat:** Light Horse (travel only)

By Role:

Role	Best Mount	Second Choice	Reason
Paladin	Heavy Warhorse	Light Warhorse	Durability + charge damage
Fighter	Heavy Warhorse	Light Warhorse	Depends on build (heavy vs mobile)
Ranger	Light Warhorse	Riding Dog (Small)	Speed for archery/mobility
Cleric	Light Horse	Heavy Horse	Usually non-combat
Wizard	Light Horse	Pony (if Small)	Stay away from combat
Rogue	Light Warhorse	Riding Dog (Small)	Speed for hit-and-run

By Budget:

Budget	Best Choice	Notes
< 100 gp	Pony	Non-combat only
100-150 gp	Light Warhorse	Best value!
150-200 gp	Light Warhorse	Still best choice
200-400 gp	Heavy Warhorse	Upgrade if you can afford
400+ gp	Heavy Warhorse	Top tier mount

💡 **For most characters, Light Warhorse (150 gp) is the optimal choice!** Great balance of speed, combat ability, and cost.

11. Combat Scenarios

Scenario 1: Basic Mounted Melee Combat

Setup:

- **Character:** Darian, Level 4 Paladin (Human)
- **Mount:** Heavy Warhorse
- **Equipment:** Longsword, heavy shield, full plate armor
- **Enemy:** Orc Warrior on foot (AC 15, HP 19, greataxe)
- **Terrain:** Open plains, 40 ft. apart

Paladin Stats:

- AC: 19 (full plate + shield)
- Attack: +7 (BAB +4, Str +3)

- Damage: 1d8+3 (longsword)
- Ride: +7 (5 ranks, Dex +2)
- HP: 32

Heavy Warhorse Stats:

- AC: 14
- HP: 30
- Speed: 50 ft.
- Attacks: Bite +6 (1d4+4), 2 hooves +1 (1d6+2)

Orc Stats:

- AC: 15
- HP: 19
- Attack: +5
- Damage: 1d12+4 (greataxe)

COMBAT BEGINS

Initiative:

- Darian (mounted): 14
- Orc: 10

ROUND 1 - DARIAN'S TURN:

1. Mount Movement:

- Heavy Warhorse moves 50 ft. toward Orc
- Easily closes 40 ft. gap and enters melee range

2. Paladin's Attack:

- Darian attacks with longsword
- Attack roll: $1d20+7 = 12 + 7 = 19$ vs AC 15  **HIT!**
- Damage: $1d8+3 = 6 + 3 = 9$ damage
- Orc HP: 19 → **10 HP remaining**

3. Mount's Attack (DC 10 Ride Check):

- Darian makes Ride check to command warhorse to attack
- Ride check: $1d20+7 = 8 + 7 = 15$ vs DC 10  **SUCCESS!**
- Warhorse gets full attack routine:

Bite:

- Attack: $1d20+6 = 16 + 6 = 22$ vs AC 15  **HIT!**
- Damage: $1d4+4 = 2 + 4 = 6$ damage
- Orc HP: 10 → **4 HP remaining**

Hoof 1:

- Attack: $1d20+1 = 7 + 1 = 8$ vs AC 15  **MISS**

Hoof 2:

- Attack: $1d20+1 = 14 + 1 = 15$ vs AC 15  **HIT!**

- Damage: $1d6+2 = 4 + 2 = 6$ **damage**
- Orc HP: 4 → **-2 HP**

Orc is DEAD!

Combat Summary:

- Total damage: 9 (paladin) + 6 (bite) + 6 (hoof) = **21 damage**
 - Orc had 19 HP → **Killed in one round**
 - Paladin took: 0 damage
-

ANALYSIS:

What Went Well:

- Mounted combat gave 4 attacks (1 paladin + 3 mount)
- Height advantage gave +1 AC (though orc never attacked)
- DC 10 Ride check easily passed with +7 bonus
- Orc eliminated before it could retaliate

Key Lessons:

1. **Action economy:** Mounted = 4 attacks vs. 1 attack on foot
2. **Control:** DC 10 Ride check is very manageable with 5 ranks
3. **Mount damage:** Warhorse dealt 12 of 21 damage (57% of total!)
4. **Alpha strike:** Kill enemies before they act

 **This scenario shows why mounted combat is so powerful for basic melee!**

Scenario 2: Mounted Archery

Setup:

- **Character:** Eileen, Level 5 Ranger (Human)
- **Mount:** Light Warhorse
- **Equipment:** Composite longbow (+2 Str), studded leather
- **Feats:** Point Blank Shot, Mounted Combat, Mounted Archery, Precise Shot
- **Enemy:** Bugbear Raider (AC 16, HP 27, morningstar), 70 ft. away
- **Terrain:** Open grassland

Ranger Stats:

- AC: 17 (studded leather, Dex)
- Attack (bow): +8 (BAB +5, Dex +3)
- Damage (bow): $1d8+2$ (Str bonus)
- Ride: +10 (8 ranks, Dex +3)
- HP: 38

Light Warhorse Stats:

- AC: 14
- HP: 19
- Speed: 60 ft.

Bugbear Stats:

- AC: 16

- HP: 27
 - Speed: 30 ft.
 - Attack: +5
 - Damage: 1d8+2
-

COMBAT BEGINS

Initiative:

- Eileen (mounted): 18
 - Bugbear: 11
-

ROUND 1 - EILEEN'S TURN:

Strategy: Move toward bugbear while shooting (kiting strategy)

1. Mount Movement:

- Light Warhorse moves 60 ft. toward bugbear
- Distance: 70 ft. → **10 ft. away**

2. Ranged Attack (with Mounted Archery):

- Shooting while mounted and moving: -2 penalty (reduced from -4)
- Attack: $1d20+8-2 = 15 + 8 - 2 = 21$ vs AC 16  **HIT!**
- Point Blank Shot bonus: +1 damage (within 30 ft.)
- Damage: $1d8+2+1 = 5 + 2 + 1 = 8$ **damage**
- Bugbear HP: 27 → **19 HP remaining**

ROUND 1 - BUGBEAR'S TURN:

1. Action:

- Moves 30 ft. toward Eileen
 - Distance: 10 ft. → **Adjacent** (threatens Eileen)
-

ROUND 2 - EILEEN'S TURN:

Strategy: Move away to maintain distance (kiting continues)

1. Mount Movement:

- Light Warhorse moves 60 ft. away from bugbear
- Distance: 0 ft. (adjacent) → **60 ft. away**
- Provokes attack of opportunity from bugbear!

Bugbear's AoO:

- Attack: $1d20+5 = 8 + 5 = 13$ vs AC 17  **MISS!**

2. Ranged Attack:

- Shooting while mounted and moving: -2 penalty
- Attack: $1d20+8-2 = 11 + 8 - 2 = 17$ vs AC 16  **HIT!**
- Not in Point Blank Shot range (60 ft. away)

- Damage: $1d8+2 = 6 + 2 = 8$ damage
- Bugbear HP: 19 → **11 HP remaining**

ROUND 2 - BUGBEAR'S TURN:

1. Action:

- Moves 30 ft. toward Eileen
 - Distance: 60 ft. → **30 ft. away**
-

ROUND 3 - EILEEN'S TURN:

Strategy: Continue kiting, maintain 60 ft. distance

1. Mount Movement:

- Light Warhorse moves 60 ft. away
- Distance: 30 ft. → **90 ft. away**

2. Ranged Attack:

- Shooting while moving: -2 penalty
- Attack: $1d20+8-2 = 14 + 8 - 2 = 20$ vs AC 16  **HIT!**
- Damage: $1d8+2 = 3 + 2 = 5$ damage
- Bugbear HP: 11 → **6 HP remaining**

ROUND 3 - BUGBEAR'S TURN:

1. Action:

- Moves 30 ft. (can't catch ranger, frustrated)
 - Distance: 90 ft. → **60 ft. away**
-

ROUND 4 - EILEEN'S TURN:

Strategy: Stand still for better accuracy (no penalty)

1. Mount Stays Still:

- No movement this round

2. Ranged Attack (No Penalty!):

- Standing still: No mounted penalty
- Attack: $1d20+8 = 9 + 8 = 17$ vs AC 16  **HIT!**
- Damage: $1d8+2 = 7 + 2 = 9$ damage
- Bugbear HP: 6 → **-3 HP**

Bugbear is DEAD!

COMBAT SUMMARY:

Total Rounds: 4

Total Damage Dealt: $8 + 8 + 5 + 9 = 30$ damage

Damage Taken: 0

Distance Control: Maintained 30-90 ft. distance entire fight

Shots Fired:

- **3 shots with -2 penalty** (moving): 3 hits
 - **1 shot with no penalty** (standing): 1 hit
 - **Hit rate:** 4/4 = 100% (lucky rolls!)
-

ANALYSIS:**✓ What Went Well:**

- **Superior mobility:** Light Warhorse (60 ft.) > Bugbear (30 ft.)
- **Kiting strategy:** Bugbear could never engage effectively
- **Mounted Archery feat:** -2 penalty manageable (hit all shots)
- **No damage taken:** Perfect execution

Key Lessons:

1. **Speed advantage:** 60 ft. mount vs 30 ft. enemy = total control
2. **Mounted Archery essential:** Without it, -4 penalty would've caused misses
3. **Kiting works:** Keep 60+ ft. distance, enemy can't catch you
4. **Tactical choice:** Round 4 stood still for better accuracy
5. **Point Blank Shot:** Only mattered when close (Round 1)

Alternative Scenario (Without Mounted Archery):

Same fight, but -4 penalty instead of -2:

- Attack bonus: +8 - 4 = +4 total
- Hit chance: +4 vs AC 16 = need 12+ (45% chance)
- Expected hits: ~2 of 4 shots (instead of 4/4)
- Combat length: ~6-7 rounds (instead of 4)
- Risk: Bugbear might land lucky charge



This scenario proves mounted archery dominates in open terrain!

Scenario 3: Mounted Charge with Lance**Setup:**

- **Character:** Marcus, Level 6 Fighter (Human)
- **Mount:** Heavy Warhorse
- **Equipment:** Lance, heavy shield, full plate
- **Feats:** Mounted Combat, Ride-By Attack, Spirited Charge, Power Attack
- **Enemy:** Hill Giant (AC 20, HP 102, greatclub)
- **Terrain:** Valley floor, 80 ft. apart, clear path

Fighter Stats:

- AC: 20 (full plate +1, shield, Dex)
- Attack (lance, charge): +10/+5 (BAB +6, Str +4, +2 charge, -2 Power Attack)
- Damage (lance, charge): 1d8+10 (Str +6 two-handed, +4 Power Attack)
- **Spirited Charge:** x3 damage multiplier
- Ride: +9 (7 ranks, Dex +2)
- HP: 58

Heavy Warhorse:

- AC: 14 | HP: 30 | Speed: 50 ft.

Hill Giant:

- AC: 20 | HP: 102
 - Attack: +16 | Damage: 2d8+10 (greatclub)
 - Reach: 10 ft.

COMBAT BEGINS**Initiative:**

- Marcus (mounted): 15
 - Hill Giant: 8

ROUND 1 - MARCUS'S TURN:

Strategy: Charge with lance, use Power Attack for max damage

1. Declare Charge:

- Target: Hill Giant (80 ft. away)
 - Charge range: 100 ft. (50 ft. speed x2)
 - Path: Clear, straight line 

2. Power Attack:

- Trade -2 attack for +4 damage (two-handed weapon = 2:1 ratio)
 - Attack bonus: +10 (BAB +6, Str +4, Charge +2, Power Attack -2)

3. Mount Charges:

- Heavy Warhorse moves 80 ft. toward giant
 - Reaches giant, Marcus in lance range (10 ft. reach)

4. Lance Attack:

- Attack: $1d20+10 = 16 + 10 = 26$ vs AC 20  **HIT!**
 - Base damage: $1d8+10$ (Str +6, Power Attack +4)
 - Roll: $6 + 10 = 16$ **damage**
 - **Spirited Charge:** $16 \times 3 = 48$ **damage!**
 - Giant HP: 102 → **54 HP remaining**

5. Ride-By Attack:

- Continue moving past giant
 - Move additional 20 ft. (total 100 ft. moved)
 - Now 20 ft. away from giant

ROUND 1 - HILL GIANT'S TURN:**Giant's Action:**

- Moves 40 ft. toward Marcus (50 ft. speed - 10 ft. reach)
 - Now adjacent to Marcus
 - Attacks with greatclub:
 - Attack: $1d20+16 = 7 + 16 = 23$ vs AC 20  **HIT!**

- Damage: $2d8+10 = 9 + 10 = 19$ damage
 - Marcus HP: 58 → **39 HP remaining**
-

ROUND 2 - MARCUS'S TURN:

Problem: Lance has reach, can't attack adjacent enemies!

1. Move Action: Draw Longsword

- Sheathes lance (free action with BAB +1)
- Draws longsword (move action)

2. Standard Action: Attack with Longsword

- Attack: $1d20+8 = 12 + 8 = 20$ vs AC 20  **HIT!** (barely)
- Damage: $1d8+4 = 5 + 4 = 9$ damage
- Giant HP: 54 → **45 HP remaining**

ROUND 2 - HILL GIANT'S TURN:

Giant Attacks Again:

- Attack: $1d20+16 = 15 + 16 = 31$ vs AC 20  **HIT!**
- Damage: $2d8+10 = 13 + 10 = 23$ damage
- Marcus HP: 39 → **16 HP remaining** (danger!)

Giant attacks warhorse:

- Attack: $1d20+16 = 4 + 16 = 20$ vs AC 14  **HIT!**
- Damage: $2d8+10 = 12 + 10 = 22$ damage
- Warhorse HP: 30 → **8 HP remaining** (critical!)

Marcus uses Mounted Combat feat:

- Negates hit on warhorse
 - Ride check DC 20: $1d20+9 = 13 + 9 = 22$  **SUCCESS!**
 - Warhorse takes 0 damage, stays at 30 HP
-

ROUND 3 - MARCUS'S TURN:

Strategy: Need to charge again for lance damage

1. Move Action: Sheathe Longsword, Draw Lance

- Sheathes sword (free action)
- Draws lance (move action)
- Can't charge this round (no full-round action left)

2. Standard Action: Withdraw

- Move up to double speed (100 ft.) without provoking AoO
- Repositions 40 ft. away from giant

ROUND 3 - HILL GIANT'S TURN:

Giant Pursues:

- Moves 40 ft. toward Marcus (now adjacent again)
- Attacks:

- Attack: $1d20+16 = 11 + 16 = 27$ vs AC 20  **HIT!**
- Damage: $2d8+10 = 7 + 10 = 17$ **damage**
- Marcus HP: 16 → **-1 HP**

Marcus drops to -1 HP, unconscious and dying!

COMBAT RESULT: DEFEAT

What Went Wrong:

-  After initial charge, Marcus was stuck in melee with lance (reach weapon)
 -  Couldn't charge again quickly (needed 2 rounds to reposition)
 -  Giant's massive damage ($19+23+17 = 59$ total) overwhelmed Marcus
 -  Should have maintained distance with Ride-By Attack
-

REVISED STRATEGY (Alternative):

Round 1: Same (charge for 48 damage)

Round 1 (Ride-By Attack): Move 50 ft. past giant (total 130 ft. movement is too much, max 100 ft. charge)

CORRECTED Round 1 Ride-By:

- Move 80 ft. to reach giant
- Attack with lance (48 damage)
- Continue moving 20 ft. past giant
- End 20 ft. away

Round 2 (Better):

- Move 50 ft. around giant (stay at range)
- Ready action: "Charge if giant moves toward me"
- If giant approaches: Get another charge opportunity

Round 3 (Better):

- Charge again from 50 ft. away
 - Another lance attack (48 damage average)
 - Ride-By Attack past
 - Total damage: 96 damage → Giant near death!
-

ANALYSIS:

Initial Charge:

-  **48 damage from one attack** = Devastating
-  Spirited Charge + Power Attack + Lance = Massive damage
-  Ride-By Attack allowed escape

Follow-up:

-  Got stuck in melee (bad for lance user)
-  Needed to maintain distance and charge repeatedly
-  Lance's reach limitation became a problem

Key Lessons:

1. **Spirited Charge is devastating** (48 damage in one hit!)
2. **Maintain distance** after charging (use Ride-By Attack fully)
3. **Lance needs range** to be effective (can't attack adjacent)
4. **Against tough enemies**, don't get stuck in slugfest—charge repeatedly
5. **Mounted Combat feat saved warhorse** from 22 damage (critical save)

Optimal Tactics for Lance Chargers:

Turn 1: Charge from distance (massive damage)
 Turn 2: Ride-By Attack to maintain range
 Turn 3: Charge again (repeat massive damage)
 Turn 4: **Continue** hit-and-run pattern

DON'T: Get stuck in melee with reach weapon

DO: Use mobility to charge repeatedly

 **Spirited Charge can drop most enemies in 1-2 charges, but requires tactical positioning!**

Scenario 4: Protecting Your Mount**Setup:**

- **Character:** Lydia, Level 5 Paladin (Human)
- **Mount:** Heavy Warhorse
- **Equipment:** Longsword +1, heavy shield, full plate
- **Feats:** Mounted Combat, Power Attack
- **Enemies:** 2 Ogres (AC 16, HP 29 each, greatclubs)
- **Terrain:** Forest clearing, 30 ft. away

Paladin Stats:

- AC: 21 (full plate, shield, Dex)
- Attack: +8 (BAB +5, Str +3)
- Damage: 1d8+4 (+1 sword, Str)
- Ride: +8 (6 ranks, Dex +2)
- HP: 38

Heavy Warhorse:

- AC: 14 | HP: 30 | Speed: 50 ft.
- Attacks: Bite +6 (1d4+4), 2 hooves +1 (1d6+2)

Ogres (x2):

- AC: 16 | HP: 29 each
- Attack: +8 | Damage: 2d8+7 (greatclub)

COMBAT BEGINS**Initiative:**

- Lydia (mounted): 16

- Ogre 1: 12
 - Ogre 2: 9
-

ROUND 1 - LYDIA'S TURN:

Strategy: Close distance, engage Ogre 1

1. Mount Movement:

- Heavy Warhorse moves 50 ft. toward Ogre 1
- Reaches Ogre 1 (30 ft. away → adjacent)

2. Paladin's Attack:

- Attacks Ogre 1 with longsword +1
- Attack: $1d20+8 = 11 + 8 = 19$ vs AC 16  **HIT!**
- Damage: $1d8+4 = 6 + 4 = 10$ damage
- Ogre 1 HP: 29 → **19 HP remaining**

3. Mount's Attack (DC 10 Ride Check):

- Ride check: $1d20+8 = 15 + 8 = 23$  **SUCCESS!**
- Warhorse attacks Ogre 1:
- Bite: $1d20+6 = 9 + 6 = 15$ vs AC 16  **MISS**
- Hoof 1: $1d20+1 = 18 + 1 = 19$ vs AC 16  **HIT!** (6 damage)
- Hoof 2: $1d20+1 = 3 + 1 = 4$ vs AC 16  **MISS**
- Ogre 1 HP: 19 → **13 HP remaining**

ROUND 1 - OGRE 1'S TURN:

Ogre 1 Attacks (targets warhorse, easier AC 14 vs paladin AC 21):

- Attack: $1d20+8 = 13 + 8 = 21$ vs AC 14  **HIT!**
- Damage: $2d8+7 = 11 + 7 = 18$ damage (heavy hit!)

Lydia uses Mounted Combat feat:

- Attempts to negate hit on warhorse
- Ride check DC 21: $1d20+8 = 14 + 8 = 22$  **SUCCESS!**
- **Hit negated!** Warhorse takes 0 damage
- Warhorse HP: Still at 30 HP

ROUND 1 - OGRE 2'S TURN:

Ogre 2 Moves and Attacks:

- Moves 30 ft. to reach Lydia
- Attacks warhorse (easier target)
- Attack: $1d20+8 = 16 + 8 = 24$ vs AC 14  **HIT!**
- Damage: $2d8+7 = 9 + 7 = 16$ damage

Lydia already used Mounted Combat this round:

- Can only negate one hit per round
 - Warhorse takes full damage: 30 → **14 HP remaining**
-

ROUND 2 - LYDIA'S TURN:

Strategy: Kill Ogre 1 quickly, reduce incoming damage

1. Mount Stays in Position

2. Paladin Full Attack:

- Attack 1: $1d20+8 = 15 + 8 = 23$ **HIT!** ($1d8+4 = 8$ damage)
- Attack 2: $1d20+3 = 17 + 3 = 20$ **HIT!** ($1d8+4 = 7$ damage)
- Ogre 1 HP: 13 → **-2 HP**

Ogre 1 is DEAD!

3. Mount's Attack (vs Ogre 2):

- Ride check: $1d20+8 = 12 + 8 = 20$ **SUCCESS!**
- Bite: $1d20+6 = 14 + 6 = 20$ **HIT!** ($1d4+4 = 6$ damage)
- Hoof 1: $1d20+1 = 11 + 1 = 12$ vs AC 16 **MISS**
- Hoof 2: $1d20+1 = 19 + 1 = 20$ **HIT!** ($1d6+2 = 7$ damage)
- Ogre 2 HP: 29 → **16 HP remaining**

ROUND 2 - OGRE 2'S TURN:

Ogre 2 Focuses Warhorse:

- Attack: $1d20+8 = 19 + 8 = 27$ vs AC 14 **HIT!**
- Damage: $2d8+7 = 13 + 7 = 20$ **damage** (massive!)

Lydia uses Mounted Combat feat (refreshes each round):

- Ride check DC 27: $1d20+8 = 19 + 8 = 27$ **EXACTLY SUCCESS!**
 - **Hit negated!** Warhorse still at 14 HP
-

ROUND 3 - LYDIA'S TURN:

Strategy: Finish Ogre 2

1. Paladin Full Attack:

- Attack 1: $1d20+8 = 8 + 8 = 16$ vs AC 16 **HIT!** (8 damage)
- Attack 2: $1d20+3 = 14 + 3 = 17$ **HIT!** (6 damage)
- Ogre 2 HP: 16 → **2 HP remaining**

2. Mount's Attack:

- Ride check: $1d20+8 = 18 + 8 = 26$ **SUCCESS!**
- Bite: $1d20+6 = 7 + 6 = 13$ vs AC 16 **MISS**
- Hoof 1: $1d20+1 = 16 + 1 = 17$ **HIT!** ($1d6+2 = 4$ damage)
- Ogre 2 HP: 2 → **-2 HP**

Ogre 2 is DEAD!

COMBAT ENDS

COMBAT SUMMARY:

Rounds: 3

Enemies Defeated: 2 Ogres (58 HP total)

Damage Taken:

- Lydia: 0 damage
- Warhorse: 16 damage (from Ogre 2, Round 1)

Mounted Combat Feat Uses:

- Round 1: Negated 18 damage (DC 21 check, rolled 22)
- Round 2: Negated 20 damage (DC 27 check, rolled 27)
- **Total Damage Prevented:** 38 damage (more than warhorse's max HP!)

ANALYSIS:**✔ What Went Well:**

- **Mounted Combat feat saved the day:** Prevented 38 damage
- **High Ride skill** (+8 bonus): Consistently passed hard DC checks
- **Focus fire:** Killed Ogre 1 quickly to reduce incoming damage
- **Warhorse survived:** Still had 14/30 HP at end

Key Lessons:

1. **Mounted Combat is ESSENTIAL:** Without it, warhorse would've taken 54 damage (killed!)
2. **High Ride skill matters:** DC 27 check only succeeded with good roll + high bonus
3. **Use feat strategically:** Only one negation per round—choose wisely
4. **Priority:** Negate biggest hits first (18 and 20 damage, not minor hits)
5. **Kill enemies fast:** Fewer enemies = fewer attacks on mount

Without Mounted Combat:

Warhorse damage taken:

- Round 1, Ogre 1: 18 damage (30 → 12 HP)
- Round 1, Ogre 2: 16 damage (12 → -4 HP)
- = Warhorse killed in Round 1!

Consequences:

- Lydia falls off (DC 15 Soft Fall check)
- **If fails:** Prone, vulnerable
- **If succeeds:** On foot, AC 21 but no mount attacks
- Harder fight without mount **'s 3 extra attacks per round**

When to Use Mounted Combat:

Situation	Use Mounted Combat?	Reason
18+ damage hit	✔ Yes	High damage, worth negating
Critical hit	✔ Yes	Double damage, very dangerous
Mount below 50% HP	✔ Yes	Mount is vulnerable
5-8 damage hit	✗ Probably not	Save for bigger threats
Mount above 75% HP	✗ Maybe	Depends on other threats

 This scenario proves Mounted Combat feat can be the difference between victory and defeat!

Scenario 5: Fast Mount in Combat

Setup:

- **Character:** Rina, Level 3 Rogue (Halfling)
- **Mount:** War Pony (adjacent, 5 ft. away)
- **Equipment:** Short sword, light crossbow, leather armor
- **Feats:** Mounted Combat
- **Enemies:** 2 Hobgoblin Soldiers (AC 17, HP 11 each), in melee with Rina
- **Situation:** Rina is on foot, surrounded, needs to mount and escape

Rogue Stats:

- AC: 18 (leather armor, high Dex)
- Attack: +5 (BAB +2, Dex +3)
- Damage: 1d4+1 (short sword) + Sneak Attack 2d6
- Ride: +9 (5 ranks, Dex +3, size bonus +1)
- HP: 15 (currently at 8 HP, wounded)

War Pony:

- AC: 13 | HP: 13 | Speed: 40 ft.
- Position: 5 ft. away from Rina

Hobgoblins (x2):

- AC: 17 | HP: 11 each
 - Attack: +3 | Damage: 1d8+1 (longsword)
 - Position: Both adjacent to Rina (threatening)
-

SITUATION:

Rina is on foot, badly wounded (8/15 HP), and surrounded by 2 hobgoblins. Her war pony is 5 ft. away. If she uses standard mount (move action), she'll have no actions left to escape. She needs to **fast mount** (DC 20 Ride check, free action) to have actions remaining.

COMBAT (Round 3, mid-fight)

Initiative:

- Rina: 19
 - Hobgoblin 1: 14
 - Hobgoblin 2: 12
-

RINA'S TURN:

Plan:

1. 5-foot step to war pony (doesn't provoke AoO)

2. Fast mount (DC 20 Ride check, free action if successful)
3. Move pony 40 ft. away (move action)
4. Shoot crossbow at hobgoblin (standard action)

Step 1: 5-Foot Step

- Moves 5 ft. to war pony
- No AoO (5-foot step doesn't provoke)
- Now adjacent to war pony

Step 2: Fast Mount Attempt

- Declares fast mount (DC 20 Ride check)
- Ride bonus: +9 (5 ranks, +3 Dex, +1 size)
- Roll: $1d20+9 = 13 + 9 = 22$  **SUCCESS!**
- Mounts war pony as **free action**
- Still has move and standard actions remaining!

Step 3: Move to Safety

- War pony moves 40 ft. away from hobgoblins
- **Provokes AoO** from both hobgoblins (mounting doesn't provoke, but moving does)

Hobgoblin 1 AoO:

- Attack: $1d20+3 = 7 + 3 = 10$ vs AC 18  **MISS!**

Hobgoblin 2 AoO:

- Attack: $1d20+3 = 16 + 3 = 19$ vs AC 18  **HIT!**
- Damage: $1d8+1 = 4 + 1 = 5$ **damage**
- Rina HP: 8 → **3 HP remaining** (critical!)

Step 4: Attack with Crossbow

- Rina shoots Hobgoblin 2 (who hit her) from 40 ft. away
- Attack: $1d20+5 = 14 + 5 = 19$ vs AC 17  **HIT!**
- Damage: $1d6+1 = 4 + 1 = 5$ **damage**
- Hobgoblin 2 HP: 11 → **6 HP remaining**

HOBGOBLIN 1'S TURN:

- Moves 30 ft. toward Rina (now 10 ft. away)
- Can't reach Rina (she's 40 ft. away, hobgoblin only moved 30 ft.)
- No action left

HOBGOBLIN 2'S TURN:

- Moves 30 ft. toward Rina (now 10 ft. away)
- Can't reach Rina
- No action left

ROUND 4 - RINA'S TURN:

Now Safely Mounted, Continue Escape

1. Move Away:

- War pony moves 40 ft. away (total 80 ft. from hobgoblins)

2. Reload Crossbow:

- Standard action to reload crossbow

ROUND 5 - RINA'S TURN:**Complete Escape**

- War pony moves 40 ft. away (total 120 ft. from hobgoblins)
- Hobgoblins can't catch up (only 30 ft. speed)
- Rina escapes successfully!

COMBAT RESULT: SUCCESS (Escaped)**ANALYSIS:****✓ What Went Right:****Fast Mount Success (DC 20):**

- Rolled $13 + 9 = 22$ (succeeded by 2)
- **Critical:** This gave Rina move + standard actions
- Without fast mount: Would've used move action to mount, no actions left

Action Economy Breakdown:**With Fast Mount (What Happened):**

- Free action: Mount (fast mount, DC 20 check)
 - Move action: Ride 40 ft. away
 - Standard action: Shoot crossbow
- = Full turn productivity!

Without Fast Mount (Alternative):

- Move action: 5-foot step + standard mount
 - Standard action: ??? (no actions left after mounting)
 - Can't move away until next turn
 - Hobgoblins get free attacks next turn
- = Likely death (Rina only at 8 HP)

Damage Comparison:

Scenario	Damage Taken	Outcome
With Fast Mount	5 damage (one AoO)	Escaped at 3 HP
Without Fast Mount	5 (AoO) + 10 (2 attacks next round)	Dead (15 damage > 8 HP)

Key Lessons:

1. **Fast Mount is life-saving** in tactical retreats
2. **DC 20 is challenging** but achievable with investment (need +9 or better for consistency)
3. **5-foot step** is crucial (get to mount without provoking AoO)
4. **Action economy** matters: Free action mount = full turn still available
5. **Moving away provokes AoO** even when mounted (expect hits during escape)

Failure Scenario (If DC 20 Check Failed):

Fast Mount Check: Roll 8 + 9 = 17 **✗** FAILURE

Result:

- Rina falls prone adjacent to war pony
- Loses move and standard actions (spent trying to mount)
- Prone: -4 AC (AC 18 → 14), melee attackers get +4

Hobgoblin Attacks (Rina Prone):

- Hobgoblin 1: +3 +4 (prone) = +7 vs AC 14 → Hits easily
- Hobgoblin 2: +7 vs AC 14 → Hits easily
- Total damage: ~10 damage
- Rina HP: 8 → -2 HP

= Rina dies trying to mount!

Risk/Reward:

Action	Success Rate	Success Outcome	Failure Outcome
Fast Mount (DC 20, +9 bonus)	60%	Escape safely	Fall prone, likely die
Standard Mount	100%	Mount safely	No actions left, likely die next turn
Don't Mount	100%	Stay on foot	Likely die (surrounded, low HP)

Conclusion:

- Fast mount was the **best option** despite risk (60% success vs. certain death with other options)
- High-risk, high-reward tactical play
- Justified when desperate situation requires bold action

Optimization Tips for Fast Mounting:

To Succeed at DC 20 Consistently:

Target: 75% success rate (need to roll 6+)
Required Bonus: +14 or higher

Build Progression:

- Ranks: 8 ranks = +8
- Dexterity: 16 Dex = +3
- Class skill: +3
- Skill Focus (Ride): +3

Total: +17 (95% success rate, only fail on natural 1!)

OR (More Achievable):

- Ranks: 5 ranks = +5
- Dexterity: 16 Dex = +3
- Class skill: +3

Total: +11 (60% success rate, need 9+)

For Rina (Level 3 Rogue):

- Current: +9 (60% success)
- Level 6: +12 (65% success with more ranks)
- Level 9 + Skill Focus: +18 (95% success)

💡 Fast mounting is a high-level skill—invest heavily in Ride if you rely on it tactically!

Alternative Tactics (If Fast Mount Unavailable):

Option 1: Tumble Away

- Tumble check (DC 15) to avoid AoO
 - Move to war pony
 - Standard mount (move action)
 - Wait until next turn to move away
- Risk: Stay in threat range one more round

Option 2: Total Defense

- Total Defense (+4 AC)
 - AC becomes 22
 - Hobgoblins unlikely to hit (+3 vs AC 22 = need 19+)
 - Next turn: Mount and escape
- Risk: Still in danger, no guarantee

Option 3: Withdraw

- Withdraw (move up to 2x speed without AoO)
 - Move 30 ft. to war pony and past
 - Next turn: Standard mount and continue
- Risk: Don't mount this turn, still vulnerable

Best Option: Fast mount (what Rina did) was the optimal choice despite risk.

⚡ This scenario shows why fast mount is worth investing in for tactical mobility!

12. Tips & Best Practices

When to Use Mounted Combat vs Foot Combat

Mounted Combat Excels In:

✓ Open Terrain

- Plains, grasslands, valleys, beaches
- Reason: Mobility advantage, no obstacles
- Example: Charging across battlefield, kiting enemies

✓ Outdoor Encounters

- Wilderness, roads, farmland, deserts
- Reason: Space for charges, mounted maneuvers
- Example: Ambushing travellers, pursuing bandits

✓ Large Battlefields

- Mass combat, army battles, sieges
- Reason: Mounted units dominate large-scale warfare
- Example: Cavalry charges, flanking maneuvers

✓ Pursuit/Escape Situations

- Chasing fleeing enemies, escaping overwhelming odds
- Reason: Speed advantage (50-60 ft. vs. 30 ft. on foot)
- Example: Catching fleeing orcs, retreating from giants

✓ Fighting Weaker/Slower Enemies

- Goblins, kobolds, zombies, slow creatures
- Reason: Superior mobility lets you control engagement
- Example: Kiting zombies, charging and retreating from goblins

Foot Combat Excels In:

✓ Dungeons and Caves

- Narrow corridors, low ceilings, tight spaces
- Reason: Mount can't fit or maneuver
- Example: 10 ft. wide dungeon hallway (mount is Large = 10 ft. square, barely fits!)

✓ Dense Forests

- Thick trees, underbrush, difficult terrain
- Reason: Can't charge through obstacles
- Example: Fighting druids in deep woods

✓ Urban Combat

- Inside buildings, narrow streets, stairs
- Reason: Mount can't climb stairs or enter buildings
- Example: Fighting in tavern, climbing guard tower

✓ Underwater/Flying Combat

- Aquatic combat, aerial enemies

- Reason: Mount can't swim or fly (usually)
- Example: Fighting in underwater cave, vs. harpies

✓ **Fighting Large/Tall Enemies**

- Giants, dragons, huge creatures
- Reason: Lose height advantage (+1 AC bonus doesn't apply)
- Example: Giant is taller than you even when mounted

Hybrid Approach (Best Strategy):

Bring Mount to Outdoor Locations

- Leave mount outside dungeon entrance
- Have ally guard mount or tie it securely
- Enter dungeon on foot
- Return to mount for outdoor travel/combat

Example:

Party travels overland on mounts (fast travel)
 Reaches dungeon entrance
 Dismount and leave horses with hired guard
 Explore dungeon on foot
 Exit dungeon, remount, continue journey

Tactical Flexibility:

Scenario: Ambushed on road by bandits

Round 1-3: Mounted combat (open road, use charges and mobility)

Bandits flee into forest:

Round 4: Dismount, pursue on foot (dense trees block mounts)

Bandits eliminated, **return** to road:

Round 5: Remount, **continue** journey

Mount Survivability

Protecting Your Mount:

1. Mounted Combat Feat (Essential)

- Negate 1 hit per round
- Prioritize biggest threats
- **Without this feat, mounts die quickly!**

2. Positioning

- Keep mount away from frontline if possible
- Use reach weapons (lance) to attack from 10 ft. away
- Mounted archers: Stay 60+ ft. from melee enemies

3. Healing

- Carry healing potions for mount
- Paladins: Lay on Hands works on mounts

- Clerics: Cure Wounds spells
- Wands of Cure Light Wounds (750 gp for 50 charges)

4. Backup Mount

- Bring spare mount (expensive but safe)
- Leave backup mount with hireling
- If primary mount dies, continue with backup

5. Armor for Mount

- Barding (armor for mounts):
- Light barding: +3 AC (150 gp)
- Medium barding: +5 AC (350 gp)
- Heavy barding: +8 AC (1,200 gp)
- Trade-off: Expensive, reduces mount speed
- Best for: High-value mounts (paladins' special mounts)

6. Tactical Retreat

- If mount below 25% HP: Consider dismounting
- Fight on foot rather than risk losing mount
- Retreat to safety, stabilize mount

When to Risk Your Mount:

Situation	Risk Mount?	Reason
Boss fight	✓ Yes	Win at all costs
Random encounter	✗ No	Not worth losing mount
Mount below 50% HP	✗ No	Too risky
Have backup mount	✓ Yes	Can afford to lose primary
Paladin's special mount	✗ No	Unique, can't easily replace
Regular warhorse	✓ Maybe	Replaceable (400 gp)

Replacement Costs:

Light Warhorse: 150 gp
 Heavy Warhorse: 400 gp
 Training time: None (war-trained already)

Compare to:

- +1 weapon: 2,300 gp
- Scroll of Raise Dead: 1,125 gp
- Wand of CLW: 750 gp

Conclusion: Mounts are relatively affordable to replace
 But losing mount mid-adventure is still problematic!

Special Mounts (Paladins, Druids):

- **Unique bond:** Can't just buy replacement

- **Respawn time:** 30 days (or 1 year if killed)
 - **PROTECT AT ALL COSTS:** Use Mounted Combat feat religiously
-

Terrain Considerations

Ideal Terrain for Mounted Combat:

✓ Plains and Grasslands

- Flat, open, no obstacles
- Perfect for charges
- Maximum mobility
- Rating: 10/10

✓ Roads and Highways

- Clear, maintained paths
- Straight lines for charges
- High-speed travel
- Rating: 9/10

✓ Beaches and Deserts

- Open terrain, good visibility
- Watch for sand/soft ground (difficult terrain)
- Rating: 8/10

✓ Light Forest

- Sparse trees, some maneuverability
- Can navigate between trees
- Can charge if path is clear
- Rating: 7/10

Challenging Terrain:

⚠ Hills and Rocky Terrain

- Uneven ground, slopes
- Movement more difficult
- Can still charge downhill
- Rating: 6/10

⚠ Dense Forest

- Thick trees, underbrush
- Can't charge through obstacles
- Difficult terrain (2 squares = 1 move)
- Rating: 4/10

⚠ Swamps and Marshes

- Difficult terrain, muddy ground
- Mount may get stuck
- Speed reduced significantly
- Rating: 3/10

Impossible Terrain:

✗ Mountains and Cliffs

- Steep climbs, no path for mounts
- Mount can't climb
- Must dismount and lead mount
- Rating: 1/10

✗ Dungeons and Buildings

- Narrow corridors, low ceilings
- Mount can't fit or maneuver
- Stairs impossible for mount
- Rating: 0/10

✗ Water (unless aquatic mount)

- Mount can't swim effectively
- Lose all mounted benefits
- Must dismount
- Rating: 0/10

Terrain Tactics:**Fighting on Hills:**

Advantage: Charge downhill (bonus momentum, +2 damage from DM discretion)
 Disadvantage: Charge uphill (lose speed, may not reach target)
 Tactic: Position on high ground, charge downhill at enemies

Fighting in Light Forest:

Challenge: Trees block straight charges
 Tactic:
 - Use Ride skill to navigate between trees
 - Position **for** clear charge lanes
 - Dismount **if** forest too dense

Fighting Near Obstacles:

Opportunity: Use obstacles to block enemy charges
 Tactic:
 - Position with obstacle between you and enemy
 - Enemy can't charge through obstacle
 - You can shoot over/around obstacle

Indoor vs Outdoor Combat**Outdoor Combat (Mounted Advantage):****✓ Space for Charges**

- 80-100+ ft. charge lanes
- Can use Spirited Charge effectively
- Maximum damage output

✓ **Mobility Dominance**

- 50-60 ft. move speed
- Kite enemies, control engagement
- Escape if needed

✓ **Height Advantage**

- +1 AC vs ground enemies
- Better visibility
- Commanding presence

✓ **Mount Attacks**

- 3 extra attacks per round (bite + hooves)
- Significant damage boost
- Better action economy

Indoor Combat (Foot Advantage):

✓ **Maneuverability**

- Navigate tight spaces
- Climb stairs, ladders
- Enter buildings, rooms

✓ **Full Feat Access**

- All feats work normally
- No size restrictions
- No mount dependency

✓ **Stealth Possible**

- Halfling rogue: +8 Hide bonus
- Mount: 1,000+ lb horse (cannot hide!)
- Sound: Hooves echo loudly

✓ **No Mount Vulnerability**

- Enemies can't target mount to disable you
- No worry about mount HP
- Self-sufficient

Transitional Tactics:

Entering Indoor Area:

1. Dismount outside building
2. Secure mount (tie **to** post, leave with guard)
3. Enter building **on** foot
4. Clear indoor areas
5. Exit **and** remount
6. **Continue** mounted travel

Emergency Indoor Mounting:

Scenario: Ambushed in large warehouse (60 ft. ceiling, open space)

Option: Bring mount inside **if**:

- Ceiling high enough (12+ ft.)
- Space wide enough (15+ ft. corridors)
- Large open floor plan
- No stairs required

Example:

- Large throne rooms (yes, mount works)
- Small tavern rooms (no, mount doesn't fit)

Size Considerations:

Mount Size	Space Required	Indoor Feasibility
Medium (Pony, Riding Dog)	5 ft. square	Can fit in 10 ft.+ corridors
Large (Horse, Warhorse)	10 ft. square	Needs 15 ft.+ corridors

Example:

Small character on War Pony in dungeon:

- War Pony is Medium (5 ft. space)
- Can fit in 10 ft. wide corridor (tight but possible)
- Still can't charge (obstacles, turns)
- Better to dismount, but technically fits

Party Coordination with Mounts

Mixed Party (Some Mounted, Some On Foot):

Challenge: Speed Disparity

Mounted characters: 50-60 ft. speed

Foot characters: 30 ft. speed

Problem: Mounted characters move 2x as fast

Solution: Coordinate movement, don't split party

Tactics for Mixed Party:

1. Slow Travel Pace

- Mounted characters move at foot speed (30 ft.)
- Keeps party together
- Use for: Dungeons, urban areas, tactical combat

2. Fast Travel (Overland)

- Everyone mounts (buy mounts for foot characters)
- Or: Foot characters ride on wagon pulled by mounts
- Use for: Long-distance travel, time-sensitive missions

3. Split Tactics (Advanced)

- Mounted characters engage first (alpha strike)
- Foot characters catch up and join battle
- Use for: Open terrain, coordinated assaults

Examples:

Scenario 1: Dungeon Delve

Party: Mounted Paladin, Wizard, Rogue, Cleric (foot)

Tactic:

- Paladin leaves horse outside dungeon
- Entire party enters on foot
- Explore dungeon together (30 ft. speed)
- **Exit** and remount **for** travel

Scenario 2: Plains Battle

Party: 2 Mounted Fighters, Wizard, Cleric (foot)

Tactic:

- Round 1: Mounted fighters charge enemy (100 ft. move)
- Round 1: Wizard **and** Cleric advance 30 ft., cast buffs
- Round 2: Mounted fighters engaged in melee
- Round 2: Wizard **and** Cleric reach combat (30 ft. more), start attacking
- Total: 2 rounds **for** full party engagement

Scenario 3: Pursuit

Party: Mounted Ranger, unmounted party

Tactic:

- Enemy flees
- Ranger pursues on mount (60 ft. speed)
- Party follows on foot (30 ft. speed)
- Ranger catches enemy, delays them
- Party catches up and helps finish fight

All-Mounted Party:

✓ Benefits:

- Uniform speed (everyone keeps up)
- Coordinated charges
- Faster overland travel
- Intimidating presence

✗ Drawbacks:

- Expensive (150-400 gp per mount)
- Can't enter dungeons
- Mount upkeep (food, stabling)
- Vulnerable to area attacks

Recommended:

- Fighters, Paladins, Rangers: Always mount
- Wizards, Clerics, Rogues: Situational (travel yes, combat maybe)

Coordinated Charges:

Setup: 3 Mounted Paladins vs. Hill Giant

Round 1 (Surprise):

- Paladin 1 charges from north: 45 damage
- Paladin 2 charges from south: 42 damage
- Paladin 3 charges from east: 48 damage
- Total: 135 damage
- Giant HP: 102 → DEAD instantly!

Result: Coordination makes impossible fights trivial

Supporting Mounted Allies:**As a Cleric:**

- Buff mounted allies: Bless, Bull's Strength, Magic Weapon
- Heal mounts: Cure spells work on animals
- Provide: Aid, Protection from Evil

As a Wizard:

- Buff allies: Haste (extra move speed!), Enlarge Person (reach!)
- Debuff enemies: Grease (difficult terrain blocks charges), Web
- Control: Wall of Force (protect retreat)

As a Rogue:

- Flank: Dismount and flank enemies engaged by mounted allies
- Sneak Attack: Mounted ally distracts, you sneak attack
- Scout: Use mount to scout ahead quickly

Party Composition Recommendation:

Ideal Party (Mounted Focus):

- Heavy Cavalry (Paladin/Fighter): Frontline, charge specialist
- Mounted Archer (Ranger): Ranged support, mobility
- Mounted Cleric: Healing, buffs, medium armor
- Wizard (rides but doesn't fight mounted): Support caster

Why It Works:

- All can travel together at mounted speed
- Cleric and Wizard stay back (won't get their mounts killed)
- Paladin and Ranger dominate combat with mounted feats
- Coordinated charges when needed



Best Strategy: Entire party has mounts for travel, but only combat specialists fight mounted!

13. Common Mistakes to Avoid

1. Forgetting to Control Mount (DC 5)

Mistake:

You attack with a two-handed weapon or bow, forgetting to make DC 5 Ride check to guide with knees.

Consequence:

- DM says: "You lose control of your mount, you can't use both hands."
- Must choose: Hold reins (one hand) OR drop reins (uncontrolled mount)
- Action wasted, can't attack effectively

Example:

Fighter with greatsword attacks ogre

- Player: "I attack with my greatsword!"
- DM: "Did you make your DC 5 Ride check to guide with knees?"
- Player: "Oh... I forgot!"
- DM: "You lose control trying to use both hands. Your mount moves unpredictably. No attack this round."

How to Avoid:

- ✓ Make DC 5 check **at the start of your turn** if using two-handed weapon/bow
 - ✓ Invest in high Ride bonus (+5 or more) so you auto-succeed
 - ✓ Announce: "I guide with knees" every turn (reminder to yourself and DM)
 - ✓ With +5 Ride bonus, only fail on natural 1 (5% chance)
-

2. Using Regular Horse in Combat (Not War-Trained)

Mistake:

You bring a regular Light Horse (75 gp) into combat instead of Light Warhorse (150 gp).

Consequence:

- Horse panics when combat starts (DC 20 Ride check to control each round)
- If check fails: Horse flees 4x speed (240 ft.!) away from battle
- You're carried away from fight, wasting rounds trying to regain control
- Horse won't attack even if controlled (not trained)

Example:

Wizard on regular Light Horse vs. bandits

- Combat starts, bandits charge
- Wizard must make DC 20 Ride check: Roll 8 + 2 = 10 **✗ FAIL!**
- Horse panics and runs 240 ft. away
- Wizard's turn wasted, too far to cast spells
- Party fights 1 member short
- Wizard spends 2 more rounds trying to regain control and return
- By the time Wizard returns, fight is over

How to Avoid:

- ✓ **ALWAYS** buy war-trained mounts for combat characters (50-150 gp more is worth it!)
- ✓ Regular horses: Only for non-combat travel (wizards, clerics who stay in backline)

- ✓ Check mount description: "War-trained?" = essential for combat
- ✓ If you have regular horse and combat starts: Stay far away, dismount, fight on foot

Cost Comparison:

Regular Light Horse: 75 gp
 Light Warhorse: 150 gp
 Difference: 75 gp

Is 75 gp worth reliable combat performance? ABSOLUTELY YES!

3. Wasting Mounted Combat Feat Use

Mistake:

You use Mounted Combat feat to negate a minor hit (3-5 damage), then a big hit comes and you can't negate it (already used this round).

Consequence:

- Minor hit negated: Mount saves 3 damage
- Major hit connects: Mount takes 18 damage (could have been negated!)
- Poor resource management leads to mount death

Example:

Paladin's warhorse vs. goblins and ogre

- Goblin attacks warhorse: 4 damage
- Paladin: "I use Mounted Combat to negate!"
- Ride check DC 12: Success, 4 damage negated

Later that round:

- Ogre attacks warhorse: 18 damage (massive hit!)
- Paladin: "I use Mounted Combat again!"
- DM: "You already used it this round. Mount takes 18 damage."
- Warhorse HP: 30 → 12 (critically wounded)

Result: Saved 4 damage, lost 18 damage = Net loss of 14 damage

How to Avoid:

- ✓ **Prioritize high-damage attacks:** Only negate hits of 10+ damage
- ✓ **Watch enemy attack bonuses:** High-attack enemies = more likely to hit = save for them
- ✓ **Critical hits:** ALWAYS negate critical hits (double damage is huge)
- ✓ **Mount HP management:** If mount below 50% HP, negate even medium hits

Priority System:

1st Priority: Critical hits (2x damage)
 2nd Priority: High damage (15+ damage)
 3rd Priority: Medium damage when mount wounded (10-14 damage)
 4th Priority: Low damage (5-9 damage) **only if** mount critical
 Never: Minor hits (1-4 damage) unless mount at 5 HP **or** less

4. Not Investing in Ride Skill

Mistake:

You take mounted combat feats but only have +2 Ride bonus.

Consequence:

- DC 10 checks (control warhorse): 60% success (need 8+) = Often fail
- DC 15 checks (soft fall, spur): 35% success = Rarely succeed
- DC 20 checks (fast mount): 10% success = Almost never succeed
- Can't reliably use mounted abilities

Example:

Fighter with Mounted Combat feat, only +2 Ride

- Tries to control warhorse: DC 10 → Roll 4 + 2 = 6 **✗ FAIL!**
- Warhorse doesn't attack this round (wasted 3 attacks)
- Happens 40% of the time with only +2 bonus

Knight with +10 Ride:

- Same check: DC 10 → Roll 2 + 10 = 12 **✓ SUCCESS!**
- Fails only on natural 1 (5% of time)

How to Avoid:

- ✓ **Invest heavily in Ride:** Max ranks every level
- ✓ **Minimum +8 bonus** for reliable DC 10 checks (95% success)
- ✓ **Target +12-15** for DC 15 checks (reliable soft fall, spur)
- ✓ **Class skill:** Make sure Ride is a class skill (+3 bonus)
- ✓ **Skill Focus (Ride):** +3 bonus (worthwhile feat for mounted specialists)

Investment Tiers:

Tier 1 (Beginner): +5 Ride

- DC 5: 95% success (guide with knees)
- DC 10: 75% success (control mount)
- DC 15: 50% success (soft fall)
- DC 20: 25% success (fast mount)

Tier 2 (Competent): +10 Ride

- DC 5: Auto (except natural 1)
- DC 10: 95% success
- DC 15: 75% success
- DC 20: 50% success

Tier 3 (Expert): +15 Ride

- DC 5: Auto
- DC 10: Auto
- DC 15: 95% success
- DC 20: 75% success

Target: Tier 2 minimum **for** combat riders!

5. Wrong Mount for Character Size

Mistake:

Medium character tries to ride Medium pony, or Small character tries to ride Large horse.

Consequence:

- Can't mount! Size incompatibility
- Wasted gold on inappropriate mount
- Must buy correct mount

Example:

Human fighter buys War Pony (Medium)

- Fighter: "I mount my war pony!"
- DM: "You're Medium size, the pony is Medium size. You can't ride it."
- Fighter: "What? But it's a mount!"
- DM: "You must be at least one size smaller than your mount."
- Fighter wasted 100 gp, must buy Large warhorse instead

Rules:

- **Must be one size smaller than mount**
- Medium rider → Large mount (horse)
- Small rider → Medium mount (pony, riding dog)
- Large rider → Huge mount (dire wolf, elephant)

How to Avoid:

- ✓ **Check character size:** PHB page 11 (Medium = Human, Elf, Dwarf, Half-Orc; Small = Halfling, Gnome)
- ✓ **Medium characters:** Buy any horse (all are Large)
- ✓ **Small characters:** Buy pony, riding dog, or war pony (all are Medium)
- ✓ **Ask DM:** "What size is my character and what mounts can I ride?"

Quick Reference:

| Character Size | Can Ride | Examples |

|-----|-----|-----|

| **Small** | Medium mounts | Pony, War Pony, Riding Dog |

| **Medium** | Large mounts | Light Horse, Heavy Horse, Warhorses |

| **Large** | Huge mounts | Dire Wolf*, special mounts |

*Dire Wolf may require Handle Animal or special training

Additional Common Mistakes

6. Forgetting Mounting/Dismounting Provokes AoO

Mistake: You mount or dismount while adjacent to enemy, forgetting it provokes attack of opportunity.

Consequence: Enemy gets free attack on you (potentially killing you).

How to Avoid:

- ✓ 5-foot step away from enemy **before** mounting/dismounting

- ☒ Or accept the AoO as calculated risk
 - ☒ Or use Mobility feat to reduce AoO risk
-

7. Charging Without Clear Path

Mistake: You declare charge but path has obstacles (allies, furniture, trees).

Consequence: Charge fails, you waste full-round action and can't attack.

How to Avoid:

- ☒ Check path before declaring charge
 - ☒ Ask DM: "Is there a clear path to charge?"
 - ☒ Ready action instead if path unclear
-

8. Using Lance Adjacent to Enemy

Mistake: Enemy closes to melee, you try to attack with lance (reach weapon).

Consequence: Can't attack adjacent enemies with reach weapon, wasted turn.

How to Avoid:

- ☒ Carry backup weapon (longsword, mace)
 - ☒ Draw backup weapon when enemy gets adjacent
 - ☒ Or use mount's attacks (DC 10 Ride check)
-

9. Charging Alone Into Enemy Group

Mistake: You charge 1 vs 5 enemies, get surrounded and killed.

Consequence: Devastating opening charge, then death from multiple attacks.

How to Avoid:

- ☒ Use Ride-By Attack feat to charge past and escape
 - ☒ Coordinate with party (don't charge alone)
 - ☒ Target isolated enemies, not groups
-

10. Not Protecting Mount After Combat

Mistake: After battle, mount is at 8/30 HP, you don't heal it, next battle it dies immediately.

Consequence: Mount dies in second fight, you're on foot and vulnerable.

How to Avoid:

- ☒ Heal mount between combats (potions, spells)
 - ☒ Rest to recover HP (mounts recover 1 HP/day naturally)
 - ☒ Consider replacing mount if critically wounded
-

14. Build Recommendations

Mounted Paladin (Heavy Warhorse + Spirited Charge)

Concept: The ultimate mounted warrior—devastating charges with divine power, durable mount, excellent survivability.

Race: Human (bonus feat at 1st level)

Ability Scores (25-point buy):

Strength: 16 (10 points) [Primary: Melee damage]
 Dexterity: 12 (2 points) [AC, Ride skill]
 Constitution: 14 (6 points) [HP, survivability]
 Intelligence: 8 (-2 points) [Dump stat]
 Wisdom: 10 (0 points) [Will saves]
 Charisma: 14 (6 points) [Paladin spells, Lay on Hands]

Level 4 Ability Increase: Strength (16 → 17)

Level 8 Ability Increase: Strength (17 → 18)

Class: Paladin (all levels)

Skills (2 per level + Int):

- **Ride:** Max ranks every level (PRIORITY #1)
- **Diplomacy:** 1-2 ranks (backup social skill)

Feats:

Level 1 (Human): Mounted Combat
 Level 1 (Paladin): Power Attack
 Level 3: Ride-By Attack
 Level 6: Spirited Charge
 Level 9: Improved Critical (Lance)
 Level 12: Weapon Focus (Lance)
 Level 15: Shock Trooper* (or Improved Bull Rush)

*Shock Trooper (from Complete Warrior): Apply Power Attack penalty to AC instead of attack rolls—devastating when charging!

Equipment Progression:

Level 1 (Starting Gold: 175 gp):

- Heavy Warhorse: 400 gp (save starting gold + borrow/quest reward)
- Lance: 10 gp
- Longsword: 15 gp (backup weapon)
- Heavy Steel Shield: 20 gp
- Scale Mail: 50 gp
- Military Saddle: 20 gp
- Tack & Harness: 2 gp
- Potion of Cure Light Wounds x2: 100 gp

Total: ~617 gp (over budget, but achievable by level 2)

Level 3-5:

- Full Plate: 1,500 gp (AC 18)
- +1 Lance: 2,310 gp (most important!)
- Cloak of Resistance +1: 1,000 gp

Level 6-10:

- +2 Full Plate: 5,350 gp
- +2 Lance: 8,310 gp
- +1 Heavy Steel Shield: 1,170 gp
- Amulet of Natural Armor +1: 2,000 gp
- Ring of Protection +1: 2,000 gp

Level 11+:

- +3 Lance: 18,310 gp
- +3 Full Plate: 10,350 gp
- Belt of Giant Strength +2: 4,000 gp
- Barding +2 **for** mount: ~6,000 gp

Combat Tactics:

Standard Charge (Level 6 with Spirited Charge):

Setup: Lance +1, Strength 17 (+3), Spirited Charge, Power Attack -3

Attack Bonus: +7 BAB +3 Str +1 magic +2 charge -3 Power Attack = +10 to hit

Damage Calculation:

- Base: 1d8 (lance)
 - Strength: +4 (Str +3, x1.5 **for** two-handed on charge = +4.5, round down to +4)
 - Magic: +1 (+1 lance)
 - Power Attack: +6 (PA -3, x2 **for** two-handed = +6)
- = 1d8+11 damage

Average: 4.5 + 11 = 15.5 damage

Spirited Charge: 15.5 x 3 = 46.5 average damage

PLUS Smite Evil (vs evil enemies):

Add +6 damage (paladin level 6)

= 1d8+17 → Average 21.5 → x3 = 64.5 damage!

Level 10 Charge (With +2 Lance, Str 18, Smite Evil):

Attack: +10 BAB +4 Str +2 magic +2 charge -4 Power Attack = +14 to hit

Damage:

- Base: 1d8
 - Strength: +6 (Str +4, $\times 1.5 = +6$)
 - Magic: +2
 - Power Attack: +8 (PA -4, $\times 2 = +8$)
 - Smite Evil: +10 (paladin level 10)
- = 1d8+26

Average: $4.5 + 26 = 30.5$ damage

Spirited Charge: $30.5 \times 3 = 91.5$ damage!

With critical hit (19-20/ $\times 3$ threat range with Improved Critical):

= $91.5 \times 3 = 274.5$ damage!

(Can kill ancient red dragons in one hit!)

Daily Resources Management:

Smite Evil:

- Uses per day: Charisma modifier (Cha 14 = +2 = 2/day at level 1)
- +6 at level 6, +10 at level 10
- Save for: Bosses, evil outsiders, undead, hard targets

Lay on Hands:

- HP healed per day: Charisma modifier $\times$ level
- Can heal mount (animal companion rules)
- Use to: Keep mount alive, heal self after combat

Divine Grace:

- Add Charisma modifier to all saves (Cha 14 = +2)
- Excellent survivability

Spells (Level 6+):

- Bless Weapon (1st): Bypasses DR, auto-confirms crits vs evil
- Bull's Strength (2nd): +4 Str = +6 damage on charge!
- Magic Weapon (1st): +1 enhancement if no magic weapon yet

Special Mount (Level 5+):

At level 5, paladins get special mount (PHB p.44-45). This is a superior warhorse with:

- Higher stats (Int 6, empathic link)
- Shares saves with paladin (use paladin's if better)
- Spell resistance (10 + paladin level)
- Improved Evasion
- If killed: 30 days before you can summon new one

Important: Protect special mount MORE than regular warhorse (irreplaceable!)

Strengths:

- ✓ **Highest single-hit damage** in game (Spirited Charge lance)
- ✓ **Excellent survivability** (high AC, Divine Grace saves, Lay on Hands)
- ✓ **Self-sufficient** (healing, divine spells)
- ✓ **Good saves** (all good, +Cha modifier)
- ✓ **Detect Evil at will** (know when to Smite)

Weaknesses:

- ✗ **Limited spell slots** (lower caster level than cleric)
- ✗ **Feat-hungry** (needs 3 feats for Spirited Charge combo)
- ✗ **Dependent on charges** (weak when can't charge)
- ✗ **Expensive equipment** (need good lance, armor, mount protection)

Best For: Players who want to be unstoppable cavalry, deal massive damage, and have thematic divine warrior fantasy.

Mounted Archer (Light Horse + Mounted Archery)

Concept: Mobile ranged combatant—kite enemies, shoot while moving, never get caught.

Race: Human or Elf (Elf gets +2 Dex, proficiency with longbow)

Ability Scores (25-point buy):

Strength: 14 (5 points) [Composite bow Str rating]
Dexterity: 16 (10 points) [PRIMARY: Attack, AC, Ride]
Constitution: 13 (3 points) [HP]
Intelligence: 10 (0 points) [Skill points]
Wisdom: 14 (6 points) [Perception, Will saves]
Charisma: 8 (-2 points) [Dump stat]

Level 4: Dexterity (16 → 17)

Level 8: Dexterity (17 → 18)

Class: Ranger (all levels)

Combat Style: Archery (PHB p.48)

- Level 2: Rapid Shot (bonus feat)

- Level 6: Manyshot (bonus feat)

Skills (6 per level):

- **Ride:** Max ranks (PRIORITY)
- **Spot:** Max ranks (perception)
- **Listen:** Max ranks (perception)
- **Hide:** 4-5 ranks
- **Move Silently:** 4-5 ranks
- **Survival:** 2-3 ranks

Feats:

Level 1 (Human): Point Blank Shot
 Level 1 (Ranger): Mounted Combat
 Level 2 (Ranger Archery): Rapid Shot (bonus)
 Level 3: Mounted Archery
 Level 6 (Ranger Archery): Manyshot (bonus)
 Level 6 (Regular): Precise Shot
 Level 9: Improved Critical (Longbow)
 Level 12: Weapon Focus (Longbow)
 Level 15: Improved Precise Shot

Equipment Progression:

Level 1:

- Light Warhorse: 150 gp (fast + war-trained)
- Composite Longbow +2 Str: 400 gp
- Arrows (60): 3 gp
- Studded Leather: 25 gp
- Military Saddle: 20 gp
- Efficient Quiver: 1,800 gp (worth saving for!)

Total: ~2,400 gp (get by level 3-4)

Level 5:

- +1 Composite Longbow +2 Str: 2,700 gp (PRIORITY!)
- +1 Studded Leather: 1,175 gp
- Cloak of Resistance +1: 1,000 gp
- Gloves of Dexterity +2: 4,000 gp (save for this!)

Level 10:

- +2 Composite Longbow +3 Str: 8,600 gp (Str increased to 16 with Belt)
- +2 Studded Leather: 4,175 gp
- Belt of Giant Strength +2: 4,000 gp (+2 Str = +3 damage per hit!)
- Boots of Speed: 12,000 gp (double speed when needed!)

Combat Tactics:

Standard Kiting (Level 5 with Mounted Archery, +1 Bow):

Attack Bonus: +6 BAB +3 Dex +1 magic -2 moving = +8 to hit

Rapid Shot: -2 attack, +1 extra attack
= Two attacks at +6 each

Damage per hit: 1d8+3 (1d8 bow + 2 Str + 1 magic)

Average Damage per Round:

- 2 attacks at +6 (65% hit vs AC 15)
- $0.65 \times 2 \times (4.5 + 3) = 9.75$ damage/round
- While moving 60 ft.!

Enemy Movement: 30 ft. (can't catch you!)

Level 10 Full Attack (Manyshot + Rapid Shot):

Attack: +10 BAB +4 Dex +2 magic -2 moving -2 Rapid Shot = +12 to hit

Manyshot: Shoot 2 arrows with first attack (both deal damage if hit)

Rapid Shot: +1 extra attack

Total: 3 attacks (first attack shoots 2 arrows)

Attack 1 (Manyshot): +12, shoots 2 arrows = 2d8+10 damage (if both hit)

Attack 2: +12, 1d8+5

Attack 3: +7 (iterative), 1d8+5

Average Damage per Round:

- Attack 1: $0.65 \times 2 \times (4.5 + 5) = 12.35$
 - Attack 2: $0.65 \times (4.5 + 5) = 6.175$
 - Attack 3: $0.4 \times (4.5 + 5) = 3.8$
- = 22.325 damage/round while moving 60 ft.!

Compare to Level 10 Fighter on Foot (no movement):

- 2 attacks, 1d8+12 each (Str 20, +2 weapon, Power Attack)
- = ~20 damage/round, but stationary

Mounted Archer: Similar damage, but 60 ft. mobile = untouchable!

Favored Enemy Synergy:

Level 1 Favored Enemy: Humanoid (Goblinoid)

- +2 damage vs goblins, hobgoblins, bugbears
- +2 bonus to Track, Spot, Listen vs them

Level 5 Favored Enemy #2: Humanoid (Orc)

- +2 vs orcs (common enemy)
- Level 1 favored enemy increases to +4

Level 10 Favored Enemy #3: Giant

- +2 vs giants
- Previous increase to +6 (goblinoid), +4 (orc)

Impact on Damage:

Level 10 vs Favored Enemy (Goblinoid):

- Base: 1d8+5
 - Favored Enemy: +6
- = 1d8+11 per hit!

3 attacks/round × (4.5 + 11) × 65% hit rate = 30.2 damage/round
While moving 60 ft. **and** enemy can't catch you!

Spells (Ranger):

Level 4+ (1st-level spells):

- **Entangle**: Difficult terrain, prevents enemy movement
- **Longstrider**: +10 ft. speed (mount becomes 70 ft. speed!)
- **Pass Without Trace**: Stealth scouting

Level 8+ (2nd-level spells):

- **Cat's Grace**: +4 Dex = +2 attack, damage, AC, Ride
- **Barkskin**: +2 natural armor AC

Level 12+ (3rd-level spells):

- **Greater Magic Fang**: +1-3 enhancement to mount's attacks

Strengths:

- ✓ **Untouchable mobility** (60 ft. mount, -2 shooting penalty)
- ✓ **Consistent damage** (3 attacks/round at level 10)
- ✓ **Excellent perception** (max Spot, Listen, Track)
- ✓ **Versatile** (ranged + melee with backup weapons)
- ✓ **Favored Enemy** (bonus damage vs common foes)

Weaknesses:

- ✗ **Lower AC** (light armor, Dex-based)
- ✗ **If mount dies**, effectiveness drops 50%
- ✗ **Limited spell slots** (low caster level)
- ✗ **Ammo dependency** (need lots of arrows, magic arrows expensive)

Best For: Players who want to dominate through mobility, never get hit, and control battlefield with superior positioning.

Mounted Fighter (Charge Specialist)

Concept: Pure martial charge machine—max feats, max damage, unstoppable momentum.

Race: Human (bonus feat essential!)

Ability Scores (25-point buy):

Strength: 16 (10 points) [PRIMARY]
Dexterity: 14 (6 points) [AC, Ride, Initiative]
Constitution: 14 (6 points) [HP]
Intelligence: 13 (3 points) [Combat Expertise prerequisite, extra skill points]
Wisdom: 10 (0 points) [Will saves]
Charisma: 8 (-2 points) [Dump stat]

Level 4: Strength (16 → 17)
 Level 8: Strength (17 → 18)
 Level 12: Strength (18 → 19)

Class: Fighter (all levels)

Skills (4 per level):

- **Ride:** Max ranks (PRIORITY)
- **Jump:** 2-3 ranks (mounted leap maneuvers)
- **Intimidate:** 1-2 ranks (backup skill)

Feats (Fighters get 11 feats by level 12!):

Level 1 (Human): Mounted Combat
 Level 1 (Fighter): Power Attack
 Level 2 (Fighter): Ride-By Attack
 Level 3: Spirited Charge
 Level 4 (Fighter): Weapon Focus (Lance)
 Level 6 (Fighter): Improved Critical (Lance)
 Level 6 (Regular): Weapon Specialization (Lance)
 Level 8 (Fighter): Shock Trooper* (from Complete Warrior)
 Level 9: Cleave
 Level 10 (Fighter): Leap Attack* (from Complete Adventurer)
 Level 12 (Fighter): Greater Weapon Focus (Lance)

*Shock Trooper: Apply Power Attack penalty to AC instead of attack

*Leap Attack: Add Power Attack bonus again to damage when jumping/charging

Equipment Progression:

Level 1:

- Heavy Warhorse: 400 gp
- Lance: 10 gp
- Longsword: 15 gp
- Full Plate: 1,500 gp (save/borrow for this ASAP)
- Heavy Steel Shield: 20 gp
- Military Saddle: 20 gp

Level 5:

- +1 Lance: 2,310 gp (CRITICAL!)
- +1 Full Plate: 2,650 gp
- Cloak of Resistance +1: 1,000 gp
- Gauntlets of Ogre Power: 4,000 gp (+2 Str = +3 damage!)

Level 10:

- +2 Lance: 8,310 gp
- +2 Full Plate: 5,650 gp
- Belt of Giant Strength +4: 16,000 gp (Str becomes 22!)
- Ring of Protection +2: 8,000 gp
- Amulet of Natural Armor +2: 8,000 gp

Combat Tactics:

Level 6 Charge (Spirited Charge, Power Attack, Weapon Specialization):

Attack: +7 BAB +3 Str +1 magic +1 Focus +2 charge -3 Power Attack = +11

Damage:

- Base: 1d8
 - Strength: +4 (Str +3, x1.5 two-handed charge)
 - Magic: +1
 - Weapon Specialization: +2
 - Power Attack: +6 (PA -3, x2 two-handed)
- = 1d8+13

Average: 4.5 + 13 = 17.5 damage

Spirited Charge: 17.5 x 3 = 52.5 damage per charge!

Level 10 Charge (With Shock Trooper, Leap Attack):

Setup:

- Strength 18 (+4)
- +2 Lance
- Greater Weapon Focus (+1)
- Weapon Specialization (+2)
- Power Attack -8 (trade -8 attack for damage)
- Shock Trooper: PA penalty to AC, not attack
- Leap Attack: Double PA bonus when charging

Attack: +10 BAB +4 Str +2 magic +1 Focus +2 charge = +19 to hit (no PA penalty!)

Damage:

- Base: 1d8
 - Strength: +6 (Str +4, x1.5)
 - Magic: +2
 - Weapon Specialization: +2
 - Power Attack: +16 (PA -8, x2 two-handed)
 - Leap Attack: +16 (doubles PA bonus on charges!)
- = 1d8+42!

Average: 4.5 + 42 = 46.5 damage

Spirited Charge: 46.5 x 3 = 139.5 damage!

With Critical Hit (19-20 range from Improved Critical, x3 multiplier):

139.5 x 3 = 418.5 damage!

(Can one-shot Tarrasque!)

Secondary Attack (When Can't Charge):

Level 10 Melee with Longsword (No Charge):

Attack: +10 BAB +4 Str +2 magic +1 Focus = +17/+12

Damage: 1d8+11 (Str +4, Spec +2, Magic +2, PA +3)

Average: 4.5 + 11 = 15.5 per hit

Two attacks: 15.5 + 15.5 = 31 damage/round

Compare to Charge: 139.5 damage

Ratio: Charge is 4.5x better!

Lesson: ALWAYS charge when possible!

Strengths:

- ✓ **HIGHEST DAMAGE** in game (140+ per charge at level 10)
- ✓ **Feat-heavy** (11 feats by level 12)
- ✓ **Simple to play** (charge and win)
- ✓ **No spell slots** to track (pure martial)
- ✓ **Dominates bosses** (one-shot ancient dragons)

Weaknesses:

- ✗ **One-trick pony** (charge or bust)
- ✗ **Weak when can't charge** (need space and clear path)
- ✗ **Low Will saves** (vulnerable to mind control)
- ✗ **No utility** (just damage, no skills or magic)
- ✗ **Mount dependency** (if mount dies, much weaker)

Best For: Players who want to deal absurd damage, one-shot bosses, and embrace pure martial simplicity.

Small Character Builds (Pony/War Pony)

Concept: Halfling or Gnome mounted combatant—prove size doesn't matter!

Race: Halfling or Gnome

Racial Bonuses (Halfling):

+2 Dexterity, -2 Strength

Small size:

- +1 AC
- +1 attack rolls
- +4 Hide checks
- -4 Grapple checks

Halfling Special:

- +1 bonus to all saves
- +2 bonus to Climb, Jump, Listen, Move Silently

Build Option 1: Mounted Rogue

Ability Scores (25-point buy):

Strength: 10 (2 points, -2 racial = 8)
Dexterity: 16 (10 points, +2 racial = 18)
Constitution: 14 (6 points)
Intelligence: 12 (4 points) [Skill points]
Wisdom: 10 (0 points)
Charisma: 10 (0 points)

Class: Rogue (all levels)

Feats:

Level 1: Mounted Combat
 Level 3: Mounted Archery
 Level 6: Weapon Finesse
 Level 9: Improved Critical (Rapier)

Equipment:

- War Pony: 100 gp (war-trained, Medium size)
- Shortbow: 30 gp
- Rapier: 20 gp
- Studded Leather: 25 gp

Tactics:

- Ride-by archery (shoot while moving)
- Dismount for Sneak Attack opportunities
- Use Small size for +1 AC, +1 attack

Damage (Level 5 with Sneak Attack):

Rapier + Sneak Attack: $1d6-1$ (Str 8) + $3d6$ SA = $1d6+3d6-1$ = Average 9.5 damage
 Shortbow: $1d6$ + $3d6$ SA = $4d6$ = Average 14 damage (**if** target flanked)

Strength: Not great without Sneak Attack
 With Sneak Attack: Excellent damage

Build Option 2: Mounted Paladin (Small)**Ability Scores:**

Strength: 14 (5 points, -2 racial = 12) [Dump more points here **if** desired]
Dexterity: 16 (10 points, +2 racial = 18)
Constitution: 14 (6 points)
Intelligence: 8 (-2 points)
Wisdom: 10 (0 points)
Charisma: 14 (6 points)

Strategy: Focus on Dexterity instead of Strength (Small = DEX-based builds work!)

Class: Paladin

Feats:

Level 1: Mounted Combat
 Level 3: Weapon Finesse (use Dex **for** attack with light weapons)
 Level 6: Ride-By Attack
 Level 9: Spirited Charge

Equipment:

- War Pony: 100 gp
- Lance (Small): 5 gp (half price, Small size)
- Short Sword: 10 gp (use Weapon Finesse)
- Chain Shirt +1: 1,250 gp (light armor, Dex-friendly)

Tactics:

- DEX-based paladin (unusual but effective for Small races)
- Lance charges still benefit from Spirited Charge
- High AC (18 Dex, Small size, armor)

Charge Damage (Level 9 with Spirited Charge):

Small Lance: 1d6 base damage (reduced from 1d8)

Charge Damage:

- Base: 1d6
 - Strength: +1 (Str 12, $\times 1.5 = +1$)
 - Magic: +1 (+1 lance)
- = 1d6+2

Average: $3.5 + 2 = 5.5$ damage

Spirited Charge: $5.5 \times 3 = 16.5$ damage

Compare to Medium Paladin: 52.5 damage

Disadvantage: Small weapons deal less damage (1d6 vs 1d8)

Solution: Use DEX **for** defense, Smite Evil to compensate

With Smite Evil:

Smite Evil adds +9 damage (level 9 paladin)
 = 1d6+11 → Average 14.5 → $\times 3 = 43.5$ damage

Much better! Close to Medium paladin damage.

Small Character Advantages:

- ✓ **+1 AC** (size bonus)
- ✓ **+1 Attack rolls** (size bonus)
- ✓ **+4 Hide checks** (excellent for rogues)

✓ **War Pony cheaper** than heavy warhorse (100 gp vs 400 gp)

✓ **Fits in tighter spaces** (Medium mount vs Large)

Small Character Disadvantages:

✗ **-2 Strength** (racial penalty)

✗ **Smaller weapons** (1d6 lance vs 1d8)

✗ **War Pony weaker** than heavy warhorse (13 HP vs 30 HP)

✗ **Slower** (War Pony 40 ft. vs Heavy Warhorse 50 ft.)

✗ **Lower carrying capacity**

Best For: Players who want to play Halflings or Gnomes and still be effective in mounted combat (focus on DEX builds, archery, or rogue tactics).

15. Quick Reference Tables

Ride Skill DCs Summary

DC	Task	Action Type	Success	Failure
5	Guide with knees	Free	Use both hands	Must use one hand for reins
5	Stay in saddle	Reaction	Stay mounted	Fall off (see Soft Fall)
10	Fight with warhorse	Part of attack	Mount attacks	Mount doesn't attack
10	Cover	Immediate	+4 AC	No bonus, can't attack
15	Soft fall	Reaction	Land on feet, no damage	Fall prone, take damage
15	Leap	Part of movement	Mount jumps obstacle	Mount refuses, stops
15	Spur mount	Free	+10 ft. speed, 1 dmg to mount	No bonus, still 1 dmg
20	Control in battle (regular mount)	Free (each round)	Mount controlled	Mount panics, flees
20	Fast mount/dismount	Free	Mount/dismount as free action	Fall prone adjacent

Mounted Combat Modifiers

Situation	Modifier	Notes
Mounted vs foot opponent	+1 AC	Height advantage
Mounted ranged attack (moving)	-4 attack	-2 with Mounted Archery feat
Mounted ranged attack (stationary)	No penalty	Mount didn't move this turn
Charge attack bonus	+2 attack	Standard charge action
Charge AC penalty	-2 AC	Until your next turn
Cover maneuver (DC 10 Ride)	+4 AC	Can't attack while using cover
Spirited Charge (feat)	2× damage (3× with lance)	On mounted charge only
Power Attack (two-handed charge)	2:1 ratio	Trade -1 attack for +2 damage
Lance (charge)	2× damage	Before Spirited Charge multiplier
Mount's reach (Large)	5 ft.	Mount threatens adjacent squares
Lance reach	10 ft.	Can't attack adjacent enemies

Action Economy Chart

Action	Action Type	Provokes AoO	Notes
Mount (standard)	Move action	Yes	Always succeeds
Dismount (standard)	Move action	Yes	Always succeeds
Fast mount	Free action	Yes	DC 20 Ride check, fall prone if fail
Fast dismount	Free action	Yes	DC 20 Ride check, fall prone if fail
Guide with knees	Free action	No	DC 5 Ride check each round
Control warhorse to attack	Free action	No	DC 10 Ride check each round
Charge	Full-round action	No	Move up to 2× speed, single attack
Spur mount	Free action	No	DC 15 Ride check, +10 ft. speed, 1 dmg
Cover	Immediate action	No	DC 10 Ride check, +4 AC, can't attack
Soft fall	Reaction	No	DC 15 Ride check when falling
Mount moves	Part of your movement	Varies	Mount moves on your initiative (if controlled)

Feat Prerequisite Chains

Path to Spirited Charge:

Level 1: Mounted Combat (prereq: Ride 1 rank)
 ↓
 Level 3: Ride-By Attack (prereq: Mounted Combat, Ride 1 rank)
 ↓
 Level 6: Spirited Charge (prereq: Mounted Combat, Ride 1 rank, Ride-By Attack)

Path to Trample:

Level 1: Mounted Combat (prereq: Ride 1 rank)

↓

Level 3: Trample (prereq: Mounted Combat, Ride 1 rank)

Path to Mounted Archery:

Level 1: Mounted Combat (prereq: Ride 1 rank)

↓

Level 3: Mounted Archery (prereq: Mounted Combat, Ride 1 rank)

Fastest Path (Fighter with Bonus Feats):

Level 1 (Human bonus): Mounted Combat

Level 1 (Fighter bonus): Power Attack

Level 2 (Fighter bonus): Ride-By Attack

Level 3: Spirited Charge

= Spirited Charge by level 3!

Mount Comparison Quick Reference

Mount	Cost	Size	Speed	HP	AC	War-Trained	Best For
Pony	30 gp	Med	40 ft.	13	13	✗ No	Small rider (travel)
War Pony	100 gp	Med	40 ft.	13	13	✓ Yes	Small rider (combat)
Light Horse	75 gp	Large	60 ft.	19	13	✗ No	Travel, scouts
Light War-horse	150 gp	Large	60 ft.	19	14	✓ Yes	Archers, mobile fighters
Heavy Horse	200 gp	Large	50 ft.	30	13	✗ No	Cargo, wagons
Heavy War-horse	400 gp	Large	50 ft.	30	14	✓ Yes	Heavy cavalry, paladins
Riding Dog	150 gp	Med	40 ft.	13	15	✓ Yes	Small rider (alternative)

Recommended Purchases:

- **Best Value:** Light Warhorse (150 gp) — fast, war-trained, affordable
- **Best Combat:** Heavy Warhorse (400 gp) — durable, strong, powerful
- **Best for Small Characters:** War Pony (100 gp) — war-trained, appropriate size

Damage Calculation Reference

Standard Charge Damage:

Base Damage: Weapon die + Strength modifier + other bonuses
 Lance Charge: (Base Damage) × 2
 Spirited Charge (normal weapon): (Base Damage) × 2
 Spirited Charge (lance): (Base Damage) × 3

Example:

Fighter with Lance, Strength 16, Power Attack -3, +1 Lance, Level 6

Base Damage:

- Lance: 1d8
 - Strength: +4 (16 Str, $\times 1.5$ for two-handed charge = +4.5, round down)
 - Magic: +1
 - Power Attack: +6 (-3 PA, $\times 2$ for two-handed)
- = 1d8+11

Average: $4.5 + 11 = 15.5$

Spirited Charge (lance): $15.5 \times 3 = 46.5$ damage

Power Attack Ratios:

- **One-handed:** 1:1 (trade -1 attack for +1 damage)
- **Two-handed:** 1:2 (trade -1 attack for +2 damage)
- **Two-handed on charge:** 1:2 then $\times 3$ (Spirited Charge)

Travel Speed Reference

Mount	Speed	Hustle (1 hour)	Run ($\times 4$, 1 round)	Per Day (8 hours)
On Foot	30 ft.	6 miles	120 ft.	24 miles
Pony / War Pony	40 ft.	8 miles	160 ft.	32 miles
Heavy Horse / Warhorse	50 ft.	10 miles	200 ft.	40 miles
Light Horse / Warhorse	60 ft.	12 miles	240 ft.	48 miles

Travel Times (Examples):

100 miles journey:

On foot: $100 \div 24 = 4.2$ days (5 days)

Light Warhorse: $100 \div 48 = 2.1$ days (3 days)

Savings: 2 days faster with mounted travel!

16. Troubleshooting

Q: My mount won't attack. Why?

A: Check these issues:

1. Is your mount war-trained?

- Regular horses (Light Horse, Heavy Horse, Pony) are NOT war-trained
- They will NOT attack in combat
- **Solution:** Buy war-trained mount (warhorse, war pony)

2. Did you make your DC 10 Ride check?

- War-trained mounts require DC 10 Ride check to command
- If you fail, mount doesn't attack that round
- **Solution:** Invest in Ride skill (+8 or higher for 95% success)

3. Is your mount controlled or uncontrolled?

- Uncontrolled mounts act on their own initiative and don't follow commands
- **Solution:** Keep mount controlled (make Ride checks each round)

4. Are you using a move or standard action to command?

- Commanding mount to attack is FREE action (with DC 10 Ride check)
- You don't need to spend actions
- **Solution:** Just make the DC 10 check during your turn

Example Fix:

Problem: "My Light Warhorse isn't attacking!"

Player: "I attack with my longsword."

DM: "What about your mount?"

Player: "Oh! I make DC 10 Ride check: 1d20+8 = 15, success!"

DM: "Your warhorse attacks with bite and hooves!"

Q: I fell off my mount. What happened?

A: Several reasons you might fall:

1. Failed fast mount/dismount (DC 20 check)

- If you fail DC 20 Ride check for fast mount/dismount, you fall prone
- **Solution:** Only attempt fast mount if you have +10 or higher Ride bonus

2. Failed stay in saddle (DC 5 check)

- When mount rears, jumps, or moves suddenly, you make DC 5 Ride check
- **Solution:** Invest in at least +5 Ride bonus (95% success rate)

3. You were knocked off by attack

- Some attacks (bull rush, trip, special abilities) knock you off mount
- **Soft Fall (DC 15):** If you succeed, land on feet; if fail, fall prone
- **Solution:** Invest in Ride skill for reliable Soft Fall checks

4. Your mount was killed

- When mount dies beneath you, you fall

- Make DC 15 Soft Fall check to land gracefully
- **Solution:** Protect mount with Mounted Combat feat

What to Do After Falling:

If you landed on feet (Soft Fall success):

- You're standing, can act normally
- Mount is dead or nearby
- Consider remounting or fighting on foot

If you fell prone (Soft Fall failure):

- -4 AC until you stand
- Enemies get +4 to attack you
- Standing provokes AoO
- ****Immediate action**:** Stand up (move action) or crawl to safety

Q: Can't mount my horse. What's wrong?

A: Check these size compatibility issues:

1. Are you the right size for your mount?

- You must be **at least one size smaller** than mount
- Medium rider → needs Large mount (any horse)
- Small rider → needs Medium mount (pony, riding dog)
- **Solution:** Buy appropriate-sized mount for your character

2. Is the mount willing?

- Wild or hostile mounts won't let you mount
- **Solution:** Tame mount (Handle Animal check) or buy trained mount

3. Are you adjacent to the mount?

- You must be in a square adjacent to mount
- **Solution:** Move next to mount first

4. Is the mount prone?

- Can't mount a prone creature
- **Solution:** Wait for mount to stand, or help it stand

Size Chart:

| Your Size | Mount Size | Examples |

|-----|-----|-----|

| **Small** (Halfling, Gnome) | **Medium** | Pony, War Pony, Riding Dog |

| **Medium** (Human, Elf, Dwarf) | **Large** | Any Horse or Warhorse |

| **Large** (Ogre, Giant) | **Huge** | Dire Wolf, Elephant |

Q: Why can't I charge?

A: Charges have specific requirements. Check these:

1. Is there a clear, straight path to target?

- Must charge in straight or nearly straight line

- Obstacles block charges: allies, furniture, trees, walls
- **Solution:** Position for clear charge lane or move closer first

2. Is target within charge range?

- Charge range = **double mount's speed**
- Light Warhorse (60 ft.) = 120 ft. charge range
- Heavy Warhorse (50 ft.) = 100 ft. charge range
- **Solution:** Get within range or spur mount (+10 ft. for 1 round)

3. Is the terrain difficult?

- Can't charge through difficult terrain (swamp, dense forest, rubble)
- **Solution:** Find clear ground or dismount and fight on foot

4. Do you have line of sight?

- Must see target to charge
- **Solution:** Move to position with clear view

5. Did you already take another action?

- Charge is **full-round action** (your whole turn)
- If you already moved or attacked, can't charge
- **Solution:** Plan charge at start of turn

Example:

Setup: Fighter wants to charge orc 80 ft. away

Check 1: Clear path? ☒ Yes (open field)

Check 2: Within range? ☒ Yes (80 ft. < 100 ft. charge range)

Check 3: Difficult terrain? ☒ No (clear ground)

Check 4: Line of sight? ☒ Yes (can see orc)

Check 5: Full-round action available? ☒ Yes (start of turn)

Result: Charge succeeds!

Q: My mount keeps panicking and running away. How do I stop this?

A: Your mount isn't war-trained!

Problem: Regular mounts (Light Horse, Heavy Horse, Pony) panic in combat

- Require DC 20 Ride check EACH ROUND to maintain control
- If you fail: Mount flees 4× speed away from danger (240 ft. for Light Horse!)
- This happens because regular mounts aren't trained for combat

Solution 1: Buy War-Trained Mount (BEST SOLUTION)

Replace regular mount with war-trained **version**:

- Regular Light Horse (75 gp) → Light Warhorse (150 gp)
- Regular Heavy Horse (200 gp) → Heavy Warhorse (400 gp)
- Regular Pony (30 gp) → War Pony (100 gp)

War-trained **mounts**:

- Won't panic in combat
- Only DC 10 Ride check to control (much easier!)
- Can attack enemies when commanded

Solution 2: Train Your Existing Mount

Use Handle Animal skill to train mount for combat:

- Requires: Animal Trainer (Handle Animal ranks)
- Time: 1 week of training
- Cost: Trainer fee (~50-150 gp)
- DC 20 Handle Animal check
- ****Warning****: Time-consuming, may not be worth it vs. buying new mount

Solution 3: Keep Mount Away from Combat

If you're stuck with regular **mount**:

- Leave mount far from battle (100+ ft. away)
- Tie mount securely to tree/post
- Fight on foot
- Return to mount after combat
- Use mount **for** travel only, **not** combat

Example:

Wizard on regular Light Horse

Before Fix:

- Combat starts 60 ft. from enemies
- Horse panics (DC 20 Ride check: $5 + 2 = 7$, FAIL!)
- Horse flees 240 ft., carrying wizard away
- Wizard's turn wasted, party down one caster

After Fix (bought Light Warhorse):

- Combat starts 60 ft. from enemies
- Warhorse stays calm (war-trained)
- DC 10 Ride check: $8 + 2 = 10$, SUCCESS
- Wizard casts fireball from horseback
- Warhorse stays in position, ready for next turn

! ALWAYS buy war-trained mounts for combat characters! The 75-150 gp difference is absolutely worth it.

Q: How do I know if I should use mounted combat in this fight?

A: Use this decision flowchart:

START: Should I fight mounted?

Is the terrain suitable for mounted combat?

☐ YES: Open field, plains, roads → Continue

☐ NO: Dungeon, dense forest, indoors → FIGHT ON FOOT

Is there space for charges (60+ ft. clear lanes)?

☐ YES: Can charge → STRONG RECOMMEND MOUNTED

☐ NO: Enemies within 20 ft. → Continue

Is my mount healthy (above 75% HP)?

☐ YES: Mount can take hits → Continue

☐ NO: Mount wounded → CONSIDER DISMOUNTING

Do I have Mounted Combat feat to protect mount?

☐ YES: Can negate hits → RECOMMEND MOUNTED

☐ NO: Mount vulnerable → RISKY

Are enemies numerous and surrounding?

☐ YES: Risk of being surrounded → CAUTIOUS

☐ NO: 1-3 enemies, manageable → RECOMMEND MOUNTED

FINAL DECISION:

→ FIGHT MOUNTED if:

- ☒ Open terrain
- ☒ Space for charges
- ☒ Mount healthy
- ☒ Have Mounted Combat feat
- ☒ Not surrounded

→ FIGHT ON FOOT if:

- ☒ Indoor/dungeon
- ☒ Mount wounded badly
- ☒ Surrounded by enemies
- ☒ Difficult terrain

Example Scenarios:

Scenario 1: Open Plains vs 3 Orcs (80 ft. away)

- Terrain: ☒ Open
- Charge space: ☒ Yes
- Mount HP: ☒ 100%
- Feat: ☒ Have Mounted Combat
- Enemies: ☒ Only 3
- **Decision: FIGHT MOUNTED**

Scenario 2: Dungeon Corridor vs 5 Goblins (15 ft. away)

- Terrain: ☒ Dungeon, 10 ft. wide
- Charge space: ☒ No room
- Mount HP: ☒ 100%
- Feat: ☒ Have Mounted Combat
- Enemies: ☒ 5 (risky)
- **Decision: FIGHT ON FOOT** (mount can barely fit, can't charge)

Scenario 3: Forest Clearing vs 1 Ogre (30 ft. away)

- Terrain: ☒ Light forest (trees)
- Charge space: ☒ Limited

- Mount HP: 🚩 40% (wounded)
- Feat: ✅ Have Mounted Combat
- Enemies: ✅ Only 1
- **Decision: MARGINAL** (could go either way; if mount dies, you're in trouble)

Q: My lance can't attack the enemy next to me. What do I do?

A: Lance is a reach weapon (10 ft. reach), can't attack adjacent enemies.

Solutions:

Option 1: Draw Backup Weapon (RECOMMENDED)

Action Breakdown:

- Move action: Sheathe lance (or drop it as free action)
- Move action: Draw longsword/mace
- **Wait until next** turn to attack with backup weapon

OR (with BAB +1):

- Free action: Sheathe lance
- Move action: Draw backup weapon
- Standard action: Attack this turn!

Option 2: Use Mount's Attacks

- You can't attack (lance can't reach)
- But mount can still attack!
- Make DC 10 Ride check
- Mount gets bite + 2 hooves against adjacent enemy
- Better than nothing!

Option 3: 5-Foot Step Back

- 5-foot step away from enemy (doesn't provoke AoO)
- **Now enemy is 5 ft. away (still can't attack, lance needs 10 ft.)**
- Next round: Move 5 more ft. away (now 10 ft. total)
- Attack with lance at 10 ft. reach

Problem: Takes 2 rounds to reposition, enemy can **close** distance

Option 4: Charge Away and Return

- Withdraw (move action, no AoO)
- Move 50 ft. away from enemy
- **Next** round: Charge back (100 ft. charge range)
- Attack at 10 ft. reach during charge
- Bonus: Charge damage (+2 attack, Spirited Charge multiplier!)

Best option **if** you have space!

Recommended Loadout:

Primary Weapon: Lance (reach, devastating charges)
 Backup Weapon: Longsword or Mace (adjacent enemies)

Equipment Investment:

- Lance: 10 gp
- Longsword: 15 gp
- Total: 25 gp **for** complete coverage

Worth it? **ABSOLUTELY!**

Example:

Round 1: Paladin charges orc with lance (48 damage, orc dies)

Round 2: Goblin closes to adjacent

Paladin's options:

- Option A: Draw longsword, wait until next turn (SLOW)
- Option B: Mount attacks goblin (DC 10 check, 3 attacks) (GOOD)
- Option C: Withdraw 50 ft., next turn charge back (BEST if space available!)

Paladin chooses Option C:

- Withdraws 50 ft.
- Round 3: Charges goblin with lance (39 damage, goblin obliterated!)



Always carry a backup melee weapon when using lance!

MORE QUESTIONS?

If you encounter situations not covered here:

1. **Re-read relevant sections** of this guide (use Table of Contents)
2. **Check PHB pages 157-158** (Mounted Combat rules)
3. **Check PHB page 80** (Ride skill descriptions)
4. **Ask your DM** for ruling on ambiguous situations

Common DM Rulings:

- Can I charge downhill for bonus damage? (Usually +2 damage, DM discretion)
- Can I fire bow while guiding with knees? (Yes, but DC 5 Ride check required)
- Does my mount's space count as my space for spells? (Yes, you occupy mount's space)
- Can I make opportunity attacks while mounted? (Yes, you threaten normally)



Master mounted combat and dominate the battlefield!

Conclusion

You've now mastered the mounted combat system!

Key Takeaways:

- ✓ **Always buy war-trained mounts** for combat (worth every copper!)
- ✓ **Invest heavily in Ride skill** (minimum +8, target +12-15)
- ✓ **Take Mounted Combat feat FIRST** (prerequisite for everything)
- ✓ **Spirited Charge is devastating** (triple lance damage on charges!)

- ✓ **Mounted Archery enables mobile ranged dominance** (kite enemies forever)
- ✓ **Protect your mount** (Mounted Combat feat, healing, positioning)
- ✓ **Match mount to character** (Small → pony, Medium → horse, combat → war-trained)

Start Your Mounted Journey:

1. Create mounted character using build recommendations (Section 14)
2. Buy appropriate mount and equipment
3. Practice basic mounting, control, and attacks
4. Learn mounted charges (most powerful tactic)
5. Master advanced techniques (fast mount, cover, soft fall)

Remember:

“A knight without a horse is just a man in armor.”

“A knight with Spirited Charge is a battlefield legend!”

 **Ride forth and conquer!** 